

QUIET HEART



Prologue

“The Promise in the Sky”

The river in Koh Thom did more than move.
It felt alive.

The water moved slowly, warm under the sun. Light danced on its surface, soft and calm, as if the river was sharing quiet memories of the land. The afternoon glow stretched across the water, turning it into gold.

Old wooden boats rested near the shore, tied to bamboo poles worn smooth by time. Those poles had seen children laugh, couples meet, and fishers return home with empty nets but full hearts. Tall grass by the bank swayed gently, moving with the breeze like it was listening.

On a small wooden bridge, faded and uneven, sat a young girl.

Her name was Aura Rebern.

Some people called her “Little Bird” because she ran fast and never stayed still. Others called her “Sky Girl” because her eyes looked far away, filled with light. But inside, she answered only to one name—
Aura.

Her legs hung over the edge of the bridge, her feet close to the water. The wood beneath her made soft sounds, not loud or sharp, but familiar, like it knew her well.

Aura leaned back and looked up.

The sky above Koh Thom felt endless that day—wide, open, and clear, like it could hold every dream that ever existed.

Her cousin sat nearby, biting into a sour mango.

“Why do you always stare up there?” he asked. “There’s nothing to see.”

Aura kept her eyes on the sky.

She smiled gently.

“There’s everything,” she said.

He didn’t understand. But she wasn’t talking to him anyway. She was talking to the sky. To her, it wasn’t empty. It felt like a path. Like a promise.

She didn’t know about star signs.

She didn’t know the word Sagittarius.

She didn’t know why her heart felt restless when she looked up.

She only knew something inside her moved—quiet, warm, and strong.

A feeling of going somewhere.

A feeling that she belonged to more than just one place.

The wind lifted her messy hair. She closed her eyes and imagined floating above the world, chasing something she couldn’t name.

At that same moment, far away, a boy named Thin Limas was being born. He would grow tall and quiet, serious beyond his years, carrying thoughts he rarely shared.

For now, he was only a child.

He didn't know a girl was sitting on a bridge under the same sky.

He didn't know their lives were slowly bending toward each other, like rivers that one day meet.

Aura opened her eyes and felt a soft heat in her chest. She pulled her knees close, resting her chin on them.

She didn't understand fate.

She didn't know about stars or signs.

She didn't know the sky was already weaving unseen threads.

But she felt it.

The sky remembered.

Even when people did not.

As the sun began to set, Koh Thom glowed with warm light. The river shined as if holding the sun in its hands. Aura sat quietly, wrapped in gold, her face calm and bright.

It was a moment the land would never forget:

A small girl on a small bridge in a quiet village—
with dreams wide enough to reach the world.

And somewhere else, a quiet boy breathed under that same sky.

The sky has always watched.

And sometimes, it keeps promises long before we understand them.

CHAPTER 1: At the Countryside

Koh Thom was the kind of place where mornings felt like blessings and evenings felt like memories. The land breathed softly, carrying the quiet sounds of roosters crowing, leaves rustling, and distant chatter from neighbors who all knew each other's names. Life here moved not by clocks, but by sunlight — rising, warming, fading, and returning again.

Aura grew up inside that rhythm.

The Landscape That Raised Her

Her village sat at the edge of wide rice fields, stretching endlessly into the horizon like a green ocean. During planting season, the fields were muddy and full of life — frogs leaping, birds dipping low, and farmers' reflections glowing in the shallow water. During harvest, the stalks turned gold, thick and full, swaying under the wind like dancers dressed in shimmering silk.

In the early mornings, the mist hugged the fields, forming a soft blanket that blurred the lines between earth and sky. Aura liked to walk along the narrow dirt paths, her bare feet collecting tiny pieces of morning dew. The air smelled clean, like wet grass mixed with smoke from neighbors' cooking fires.

Her home stood near the river — a small wooden house with tin roofs that clattered loudly during rainstorms. Her family wasn't wealthy, but there was always warmth: warm rice, warm laughter, warm embraces. Aura often sat by the doorway watching the sunlight creep onto the wooden floor, savoring the slow beauty of her world.

Everything in Koh Thom was simple.

Everything was familiar.

But Aura... she was different.

A Girl Made of Fire and Sky

Aura's childhood was full of contradictions that puzzled the adults.

During the day, she was everywhere — running with her cousins, chasing chickens, climbing trees, splashing in the river until her clothes were soaked and her hair tangled. She had a wildness that felt natural, like she belonged to the wind.

But at night she became soft.

Quiet.

Almost delicate.

She would sit at her window with her chin resting on the windowsill, staring at the moon until her eyes grew heavy. The sky, to her, was not just a ceiling — it was a calling. A whisper only she could hear, telling her that there was something beyond the village, beyond the fields, beyond everything she knew.

She didn't have the words for it yet.

She didn't know she was born under Sagittarius — a sign of wanderers, truth-seekers, restless dreamers. She didn't know that her fire energy was the reason she felt both deeply connected to her home and simultaneously destined to leave it.

She only knew she wanted more.

More world, more sky, more stories, more experiences.

She wanted to see oceans. Cities. Mountains. Airplanes. Snow. Lights.

She wanted to taste the world the way she tasted her mother's soup — fully, with her whole heart.

The Village's Little Mystery

Not everyone understood her.
Her parents adored her, but sometimes they exchanged worried glances.

“She thinks too much,” her mother said.
“She dreams too far,” her father added.
“But her heart is good,” they both agreed.
Her cousins loved her but often teased her.

“You’re weird, Aura,” they laughed. “Why don’t you just play like the rest of us? Why always looking at the sky?”

Aura always smiled.
She didn’t mind being different.
Being different felt like being alive.

But inside, she carried a tender softness — a heart that bruised easily. She cried when her mother scolded her. She felt hurt when her cousins ignored her. She worried about people, even when they didn’t worry about her.
Still, she never let anyone see how deeply she felt things.
Not even her parents.

She built her own small inner world — one made of dreams, stars, fire, and sky.
A Soul Already Traveling

When Aura turned ten, she began keeping a small notebook. It wasn’t fancy — just a cheap booklet she bought from the market with coins she saved. She called it her Dream Book.

Inside it, she wrote things like:
“All I want to do is travel”
“I want to learn new cultures”
“I want to go to a country with snow.”

“I want to try new foods”
“I want to meet new people”
“I want to see this beautiful earth – that we call home”
“I want to ride an airplane by myself.”
“I want to study in a big city.”
“I want to learn another language.”
“I want to see the ocean at night.”
“I want to find someone who understands me.”

She didn’t know why she wrote the last one.
It simply came out naturally, like truth spilling before she could stop it.

Aura had friends, but she often felt... different.
She felt deeply but rarely expressed it.
She loved strongly but quietly.
She trusted slowly.
She saw beauty in little things.
She was brave, but in a gentle way — not loud, not aggressive, but steady and determined.

Many Sagittarians wear their fire loudly.
But Aura’s fire was soft — glowing instead of blazing.

The River That Knew Her Name

The river near her home became her sanctuary.

On quiet afternoons, Aura sat on the wooden bridge with her legs dangling, watching the water drift by like floating glass. She talked to the river the way others talked to diary pages.

“Where do you go?” she whispered.
“What places have you seen?”
“Take me with you someday.”

The water whispered back in its silver language.

Sometimes she would close her eyes and imagine following the river until it reached somewhere vast and unknown. She imagined walking alone, with a backpack full of snacks, a heart full of courage, and the sky guiding her.

She imagined meeting someone on that journey — a tall figure with a gentle presence. She didn't know why she imagined him. She just did. A shadow of a boy she hadn't met yet. Someone with quiet eyes who listened more than he spoke. Someone whose silence felt safe, not empty. It was just a child's fantasy.

But even fantasies sometimes carry traces of fate.

Learning to Be Strong in Silence

Aura grew older. Her body changed. Her thoughts deepened. Her dreams stretched wider. She became more responsible — helping her parents with chores, reading late at night, studying hard because she wanted her future to be bigger than her circumstances.

Yet she remained lonely in a way she could never fully explain. It wasn't the loneliness of having no one around. It was the loneliness of not being understood.

People saw her as: Cheerful, Strong, Adventurous, Independent...

Cheerful

Strong

Adventurous

But they never saw her soft nights.
Her worries.

Her dreams.

Her longing.

Her hidden fears.

Sagittarius may be a sign of freedom, but even freedom-seekers crave connection.

Aura craved not a crowd, but one person.

One soul who would understand her without needing explanations.

One heart she could rest against without pretending to be strong.

But she didn't rush.

She trusted timing.

She trusted the sky she loved so much.

The Quiet Beginning of a Long Path

Sometimes, while washing rice in the kitchen or helping sweep the yard, Aura's mind drifted to unknown places. She wondered:

"Who will I become?"

"What kind of life will I live?"

"Who is waiting for me in the future?"

She didn't know that across the country, a boy was growing up too — tall, quiet, serious, thoughtful. A boy who would learn responsibility early. A boy who would guard his heart carefully. A boy whose path was already aligning slowly toward hers.

They were two separate stories, unfolding under the same sheet of sky.
Two souls shaped by different landscapes.
Two hearts unaware of how one day, they would change each other.

Aura only knew one thing for certain:
The world was calling her.

And someday, she would answer.

She sat on the wooden bridge again that evening, watching the sun sink behind the rice fields. The sky exploded into colors — orange, peach, violet, blue — like a painting stretching across the heavens.

The wind brushed against her face.

She closed her eyes and whispered:

“One day.”

The sky, as always, listened in silence.

CHAPTER 2: The City Calling

Morning in Koh Thom always arrived gently, like a mother waking her child. But the morning Aura left came with a strange heaviness — as if the air itself knew something was ending. The sky was pale, washed in early sunlight, and the village seemed quieter than usual. Even the chickens crowed softly, as though not to disturb the moment.

Aura stood outside her house with a small bag and a bigger heart. Her mother fussed over the straps, her father checked the zippers twice, and her little cousin stared wide-eyed at the idea of Aura leaving the village.

“You’ll come back, right?” the child asked.

Aura knelt down and smiled. “Of course. But I need to go first. I need to learn... and grow.”

Her cousin didn’t understand what that meant.

Maybe Aura didn’t fully understand either.

All she knew was that something inside her was pulling her forward, like a thread tugging gently but insistently at her ribs.

The Road That Led Away

The bus station was a simple dusty stop with a metal bench and a shelter that barely shaded anyone. But that morning, to Aura, it looked like a threshold—one of those invisible doors people cross through without realizing that everything after will be different.

Her parents stood close to her, each holding one of her hands. Their palms were rough and warm—comforting in a way no city would ever replace.

“Be careful,” her mother said for the tenth time.

Aura nodded.

“Study hard,” her father added.

She nodded again.

“Don’t trust people too easily.”

Another nod.

“And call us every day.”

Aura laughed softly, but she didn’t trust her voice to stay strong if she spoke.

When the bus finally groaned to a stop, she climbed aboard with trembling hands. She found a seat by the window, pressed her bag against her lap, and watched her parents grow smaller as the bus hissed into motion.

Her mother waved both hands like the world was ending.

Her father nodded stoically, pretending he was completely fine.

Aura bit her lip until it stung.

Her chest felt tight.

Her throat thickened.

She kept her eyes on the sky, not the ground.

The sky would always give her courage.

The City Opening Before Her

Phnom Penh announced itself long before she arrived.

First came the noise — a humming, swelling noise she'd never heard in Koh Thom. Then came the movement — the blur of markets, trucks, motorcycles, tuk-tuks, and people crossing streets with wild confidence.

And finally, the buildings.

Tall.

Gray.

Modern.

Crowded.

Aura pressed her forehead to the window as if that could help her absorb everything. Her heart fluttered with excitement, fear, hope, and curiosity all at once. This is the world outside the fields...

The city felt alive. Not quietly alive like Koh Thom, but fiercely alive — like a pulse, a heartbeat, a drum.

Aura stepped off the bus and was immediately swallowed by a swirl of energy. Voices blended into each other. Smells mixed — grilled food, gasoline, perfume, dust, rain on pavement. Motorbikes zipped past like they had wings.

Aura gripped her bag tightly and whispered to herself:

“You got this, Aura. You’re here now.”

The sky above the city was smaller, framed by buildings instead of rice fields. But she still looked up, trying to find a piece of the endless blue she grew up loving.

She breathed deeply.

“Okay, universe,” she murmured. “I’m ready.”

Her First Home in the City

Aura stayed in a dorm near the university — a narrow building painted in faded yellow, with balconies lined by laundry hanging like colorful flags. Inside her room, everything felt unfamiliar: the mattress too thin, the ceiling too close, the air too warm.

But for the first time in her life, she was alone.

And something inside her liked that.

She unpacked slowly, placing her clothes neatly, arranging her books, and putting her Dream Book right beside her pillow. She sat on the bed afterward, legs crossed, staring at the window that looked out onto a noisy street.

It wasn’t Koh Thom.

It wasn’t quiet.

It wasn’t peaceful.

But it was hers — her new world, her new beginning.

For someone born with Sagittarius fire, the unknown didn’t scare her.
It thrilled her.

Even if her hands were still shaking a little.

The Landscape of the University

Her first day of university felt like stepping into another universe.

The campus stretched out in a mix of modern buildings, shaded walkways, grassy courtyards, and old trees. Students rushed in every direction, holding books, laughing loudly, hurrying to class.

Aura walked slowly, absorbing everything.
She noticed:

the smooth stone paths that warmed under the sun
lotus ponds reflecting the sky in soft ripples
a cafeteria overflowing with voices and smells
a wide staircase where students sat to chat between classes
the tall academic building whose windows mirrored clouds like captured dreams

The campus had beauty — a different kind of beauty than Koh Thom, but real nonetheless.

It was a place full of ambition, movement, and silent stories unfolding in every corner.

Aura felt small.

But she also felt a spark inside her chest, like a tiny flame burning brighter with every step.

Learning the Rhythm of the City

Life settled into patterns.

Morning rushes.

Afternoon lectures.

Crowded hallways.

Evening walks past glowing street vendors.

Nights filled with homework and cheap instant noodles.

Aura started noticing things:

Some students walked in groups, laughing easily.

Some looked tired with dark circles under their eyes.

Some seemed like they belonged here from the beginning.

But Aura always walked alone at first — not out of isolation, but because she was careful. She didn't open her heart quickly. She didn't trust easily. She didn't want to pour herself into the wrong people.

Yet she was kind.

Soft-speaking.

Welcoming in a quiet way.

People approached her little by little.

“Are you from the countryside?”

“What high school did you go to?”

“You're so quiet—are you shy?”

Aura answered gently, always with a polite smile.

She wasn't shy.

She was observant.

Cautious.

Thoughtful.

Her softness wasn't weakness — it was a shield.

A Lonely Kind of Strong

At night, the city lights glowed outside her window.
She would lie on her bed, staring at the ceiling, letting exhaustion soak into her bones.
Some nights, she cried silently.

Not because she regretted leaving home, but because the world felt too big — too loud,
too fast, too indifferent. But Aura never cried loudly. She cried like rain on a lake — quiet,
barely visible, but deep.

She missed:

the smell of rice fields after rain
the laughter of her cousins
her mother's warm hands
her father's soft humming while working
But she stayed strong.

Sagittarius girls break, but they break privately.
Sagittarius girls feel, but they feel like fire — quietly, intensely, and with purpose.
Sagittarius girls get lonely, but they keep moving.

Aura kept moving.

Discovering Her Own Identity

Day by day, she grew more confident, learned to navigate the city's traffic. She found her
favorite street food stall, made acquaintances in class, joined a study group, learned new words,
new ideas, new dreams.

Bit by bit, she shed old fears and gained new strengths. But she never lost her softness.
Never lost her sky-loving heart.

Sometimes, after class, she climbed to the top floor of the university building and stared
at the sunset. It wasn't the same as Koh Thom's sunsets — but in its own way, it was beautiful.
Below her, motorbikes roared.

Around her, the wind tugged at her hair. Above her, the sky glowed in orange and purple. She whispered:

“One day, I’ll see the sky from another country.”

A dream spoken softly, but with conviction. Meanwhile, Somewhere Else.

While Aura adjusted to her new world, the boy born under the same sky grew into his own life. His days were filled with responsibilities — study, work, helping his family. He wasn’t one to talk much. People described him as tall, serious, quiet, and reliable.

He didn’t believe in fate.

Or stars.

Or the idea that someone was “meant for him.”

His world was simple.

Predictable.

Safe.

He had no idea that destiny was already drawing lines between him and a girl with river eyes and fire in her soul. He had no idea how one day, her laughter would soften him, and her tears would teach him tenderness. He didn’t know he was already walking toward her, slowly, unknowingly — each step bringing their paths closer.

The Final Line of the Chapter

At night, Aura sat on the edge of her narrow dorm bed. The window was open, letting in the warm city breeze. She looked at the piece of sky she could see — small, framed by buildings, but still hers.

She whispered to it the same words she had whispered in Koh Thom:

“One day.”

And though she didn’t know it, the sky whispered back:

“Soon.”

CHAPTER 3: A Lonely Kind of Strong

The city taught Aura many things in her first months — some gently, some harshly, and some in ways she would only understand years later. Life in Phnom Penh didn't pause for anyone. It rushed forward like the river after a storm, pulling everything — and everyone — along with it.

Aura tried to keep up.

She learned to walk faster, think quicker, speak more confidently. But inside, her heart still beat with the slow rhythm of Koh Thom — soft, steady, searching.

The Hidden Weight of Independence

People admired Aura almost instantly.

“You're strong.”

“You're responsible.”

“You don't rely on anyone.”

“You're so mature.”

She heard these words so often that she began to wonder if that was all anyone saw — her strength, her independence, her ability to handle things alone. But they didn't see her quiet nights. They didn't hear her thoughts. They didn't know how much she longed for someone—not many—just one person—to understand her without needing explanations.

There's a loneliness that comes with being “the strong one.” It's invisible, but heavy, sits on the chest like unsaid words, lingers in the spaces between laughter and silence. Aura carried that loneliness like a second heartbeat. She never burdened others with her fears, never asked for help unless she absolutely couldn't avoid and never let anyone see her cry.

Sagittarius girls fall apart quietly — not because they want to hide, but because they don't want to be misunderstood. Aura's strength wasn't a shield she chose. It was a shield life had taught her to build.

University Life, Unfiltered

The landscape of her university changed with seasons. In the dry months, the courtyard turned dusty, and the old trees cast long shadows over the pavement. Students sat beneath them, scrolling through their phones or eating snacks wrapped in brown paper. The heat made everyone slow, tired, drained.

In the rainy season, puddles formed everywhere. The smell of wet concrete filled the air, and students rushed from building to building with textbooks clutched to their chests. Thunder would roll across the sky, echoing between the tall walls, and Aura found comfort in the sound. Rain reminded her of Koh Thom. It felt like a familiar hug.

When it rained, she always paused under a roof, watching droplets fall like silver strings. She admired how the campus turned soft, how reflections danced on the ground, how the world felt quieter despite the noise.

Sometimes she wished someone stood beside her to see the beauty the way she saw it.
Someone gentle.
Someone observant.
Someone who understood silence.

She didn't know that someone like that existed — and that he, too, was waiting without realizing he was waiting.

The Girl Who Blended In and Stood Out

Aura was friendly enough to speak to anyone, but reserved enough that few got close. She wasn't loud or attention-seeking. She didn't dress extravagantly or talk dramatically. Yet people noticed her.

Her beauty was the kind that didn't scream — it glowed. She had Sagittarius freshness in her features: Bright, curious eyes that held a hint of mischief
A smile that looked natural, not forced
A face that seemed open to the world, yet protected at the same time
A softness in her expressions that made people feel safe around her
A kind of inner light that made her stand out without trying

And the way she moved — lightly, gracefully, purposefully — made her feel like a breeze passing through crowded hallways. She didn't realize this and never saw herself the way others saw her.

To her, she was simply Aura — trying her best to navigate a world that felt too big and too fast. The Places She Made Her Own. Everyone needs a place to breathe. Aura found hers slowly.

1. The Rooftop of the Academic Building

It wasn't meant for students, but she found it anyway. A small door left unlocked, a stairway unused, a rooftop open to the wind. Up there, the whole campus stretched beneath her — like a map of tiny lives moving along their own paths. The city skyline rose in the distance, fierce and full of dreams.

Aura would sit by the ledge, hugging her knees, watching the sunset melt into purple. This was where she whispered her wishes. Where she let her thoughts wander freely and felt closest to the sky.

2. The Campus Garden

Hidden behind the library, full of jasmine, orchids, and small stone benches. The air always smelled sweet, even during exams when everyone was stressed and tired.

Here, Aura read her books. She loved stories — romance, adventure, history, fantasy. Anything that took her beyond the present moment. Sometimes, she imagined herself as the heroine of her own novel. But she never imagined who the hero would be and never certain that she even needed one.

3. A Small Café near the Gate

Dim lights, quiet music, wooden tables scarred with time — Aura found comfort there. She'd do her assignments or simply sip iced coffee while watching the rain fall outside. She always sat near the window.

Always looking out.

Always searching for something she couldn't name.

The Quiet Struggles She Never Spoke Of

There were days when Aura felt like she didn't belong anywhere.

Days when:

the noise overwhelmed her

the assignments piled up

the loneliness felt sharp

the future felt blurry

the city felt too crowded and her heart felt too empty

On those days, she held herself together the same way she always did — silently, gently, bravely. Sometimes she called her mother, forcing her voice to sound cheerful.

"Everything is fine," she said.

"I'm doing well."

"Don't worry."

Her mother believed her.

Aura wished someone could hear the things she didn't say. Being a Sagittarius didn't mean she wanted independence all the time. It meant she needed freedom, yes — but also understanding. It meant she could be strong alone — but she longed for a place to rest. She wondered sometimes, in the quiet hours before sleep:

“Will I ever meet someone who sees me fully?”

“Will anyone understand my fire and my softness both?”

She didn't want many people. Just one. One who could see the universe inside her.

The Boy with the Quiet Soul

Meanwhile, the boy she had never met was living his own rhythm. He grew up disciplined, learned responsibility early, didn't chase friendships or conversations. He didn't waste time on shallow things. People described him as: Serious, Polite, Focused, A bit mysterious, Tall, quite, Reliable.

He wasn't the type who fell in love easily, didn't believe in fate. He didn't think about romance much. He handled life with a kind of silent strength — the opposite of Aura's soft fire, but somehow the perfect complement.

There were days when he looked out the window during class, wondering why the world felt so quiet inside him. Why nothing seemed to truly reach him. He had no idea that somewhere in the same city, a girl with gentle eyes and dreams bigger than her fears were waiting for him — unknowingly, unknowingly.

And he was waiting for her too — unknowingly, unknowingly.

The Shift Inside Aura

As the months passed, Aura changed in ways she didn't immediately see. She became more confident — not loudly, but deeply, she made a few true friends.

She learned the bus routes, the shortcuts, the hidden corners of the city.
She began to dream differently — not only of leaving, but of becoming.
And something else changed too. She began to feel ready.
Ready for connection.
Ready to open her heart.
Ready for something real.

She didn't know what form it would take, didn't know who it would involve.
But she felt it — a faint pull in her chest, like the beginning of a new season.
A quiet shift.
A gentle awakening.
A slow, steady approach of something — or someone — toward her life.

The Last Night of the Chapter

One night, after finishing her assignments, Aura stepped onto the rooftop. The wind brushed against her face, warm with the smell of late evening. The city below shimmered with lights, like stars that had fallen onto the streets. She tilted her head back and stared at the sky — the same sky she had loved since childhood, the same sky she shared with a boy she didn't know. "Where will life take me next?" she whispered.

The wind blew softly, carrying her question into the night. And somewhere across the city, at that exact moment, a tall young man paused while walking home. He looked up for no reason, feeling a strange pull in his chest, as if someone had whispered something he was meant to hear.

Their worlds were still separate.
Their stories still unwritten.
Their hearts still strangers.

But destiny was moving slowly, quietly, inevitably
Soon — very soon — their paths would begin to shift. Not enough to collide.
Not enough to change anything yet. But enough to begin.

CHAPTER 4: The Corridor of Fate

The moment wasn't special. It wasn't magical, dramatic or romantic. Not yet. It was simply a hot, ordinary afternoon in the middle of a noisy university campus — the kind of afternoon when the air felt thick, the hallways felt crowded, and every student rushed from one class to another with heavy backpacks and heavier thoughts.

But sometimes fate hides inside the ordinary. Sometimes destiny doesn't announce itself. Sometimes the universe moves quietly, slipping meaning into moments people don't notice. This was one of those moments.

A Corridor Like Any Other

The main university corridor was alive with movement — doors slamming, sandals dragging across the tiled floor, laughter bouncing off the walls, conversations blending into a blur of sound. Posters fluttered on bulletin boards. A ceiling fan spun lazily overhead, doing nothing to ease the heat.

Aura walked through the hallway with her usual determined rhythm. Her earbuds were in, soft music filling her head, steps were confident, firm, purposeful. Her mind was full — overflowing, really — with assignments, deadlines, financial worries, daydreams of the future, and small private fears she never told anyone.

She walked like she always did: focused, in her own world, slightly distant from the noise around her. Some people walk through crowds. Aura moved through them like a wind — noticeable, but untouchable.

Students turned their heads occasionally, recognizing her familiar presence, but no one stopped her. She had that aura — soft, warm, but hard to approach without invitation.

She brushed her hair back gently as she walked, a habitual gesture she did when deep in thought.

He Saw Her Before She Saw Him

Coming from the opposite direction was a boy.

Tall.

Quiet.

Serious-looking.

Carrying a thick textbook pressed against his arm.

He wasn't the type who drew attention, didn't laugh loudly, didn't walk with a crowd. He blended into the background — or at least he believed he did.

But there was something about him that made people trust him instinctively: a gentle steadiness, a calm presence, a focused gaze that suggested he carried responsibilities he never complained about. He was thinking about a project deadline, a difficult assignment, and the work shift he had after classes. His days were full, structured, heavy — and he bore them quietly.

And then...

Through all the movement, the shifting bodies, the sound of footsteps and voices, something strange happened. The crowd parted perfectly between them. Just for a second! Just long enough.

It was nothing magical — just timing.

A coincidence.

But sometimes coincidence is simply destiny wearing a realistic mask.

The First Noticing

His eyes lifted at the exact moment she walked past the group of students between them.

And for the first time...

He saw her clearly.

He noticed the purposeful way she walked — not hurried, not slow, but with the kind of confidence people grow into through quiet strength. He noticed the way her brows tightened just slightly, a tiny crease forming when she was deep in thought.

He noticed how the sunlight from a window fell across her hair, catching faint glimmers of gold. He noticed the quiet intensity in her eyes, even though she wasn't looking at anyone.

She wasn't smiling.

She wasn't trying to impress anyone.

She wasn't performing or pretending.

She was simply herself — focused, calm, beautifully unaware of the world watching her.

Without realizing it, his steps slowed.

Just a fraction.

Just enough that he felt it.

“Who is she?” The thought surfaced uninvited.

He blinked, surprised at himself. He wasn't the type of boy who got distracted easily. He wasn't the type to let his attention wander to strangers. But Aura wasn't a stranger his mind could dismiss. There was something about her — something he couldn't name yet. A spark, A curiosity A pull.

It wasn't love.

It wasn't attraction.

It wasn't fate — at least, he didn't believe in that.

It was simply... interest.

Pure, quiet, unexpected interest.

The Passing Moment

Aura, meanwhile, continued walking, her mind in a completely different world — worrying about a research paper due next week, thinking about the ramen she might cook tonight, wondering whether she should call her mother.

She didn't slow down.

She didn't look around.

She didn't feel anything unusual.

When they passed each other, she barely glanced his way.

A quick flick of her eyes.

An unconscious gesture.

Nothing more.

A moment too small to register.

But for him...

It was enough to mark something.

Not a memory, exactly — but an impression.

When she passed him, something inside him shifted slightly, like a compass needle turning minutely toward a new direction.

He didn't fully turn his head, but he glanced over his shoulder — subtle, almost instinctive — watching her fade into the sea of students.

Observing her.

Noticing her.

Curious, even if he didn't understand why.

A Thread the Universe Pulled

Aura disappeared around a corner without ever realizing she had been seen.

And he stood still for one heartbeat longer than he meant to.

Just one heartbeat.

Just long enough for destiny to whisper:

There.

That one.

Remember her.

He inhaled slowly, shook his head as if to clear the strange lingering feeling, and resumed walking — convincing himself that it meant nothing.

He didn't know her name.

He didn't know her major.

He didn't know her story.

He didn't even know if he would ever see her again.

But the universe knew.

Aura went on with her day, entirely unaware of the boy whose quiet world had tilted slightly.

To her, it was just another afternoon.

Just another corridor.

Just another walk to class.

Nothing important.

Nothing memorable.

But fate...

Fate remembers the moments humans forget.

Later, she would look back on this day and smile — realizing she had walked past someone who would one day change her life in ways she couldn't imagine.

But not yet.

Not today.

Not in this moment.

For now, the universe murmured to itself:

“Not yet...

but soon.”

And that whisper was enough to begin everything.

CHAPTER 5: The First Connection

It happened on a day Aura never expected anything interesting to happen. The sky was dull and grey, the kind of cloudy afternoon that made the whole campus feel sleepy. Students dragged their feet along the walkways, worn out by the weight of deadlines and the rising humidity. Even the trees looked tired, their leaves drooping slightly as if exhausted from the heat.

Aura sat alone at a wooden table tucked in a quiet corner of the courtyard study area — a place she often used when she wanted silence without isolation. The table was old, polished by rain and time, shaded by a large tree whose branches curved above like a protective umbrella.

Her laptop glowed faintly in front of her, its fan humming louder than usual. She had been working on her presentation slides for hours, adjusting fonts, correcting data, rewriting sentences that still didn't sound right.

“Almost finished...” she murmured to herself.

Her eyes were tired.

Her shoulders tense.

Her mind stretched thin from stress.

Then, suddenly—

Her screen froze.

Not a flicker.

Not a glitch.

A complete stop.

The cursor stopped moving, the trackpad became unresponsive, and the fan whirred angrily as if the laptop was giving up on life.

Aura stared, horrified.

“No... no, no, no...” she whispered.

She pressed the power button.

Nothing happened.

She pressed it again, harder.

Still nothing.

Her heart dropped, sinking like a stone inside her chest.

“Come on,” she pleaded under her breath. “Don’t do this to me now... please...”

But the screen remained frozen, cold and lifeless.

She could feel her breath tightening.

Her chest tightening.

Her eyes beginning to sting.

She wasn’t just frustrated — she was overwhelmed.

The presentation was due the next morning.

She hadn’t slept well in days.

She felt alone, tired, and small.

Her vision blurred for a moment as tears threatened to spill.

Across the room, someone slowed their steps.

A boy who had been passing by — not looking for anyone, not intending to stop — paused when he noticed the sudden tension in Aura’s posture. He noticed the way she exhaled shakily, the way her fingers hovered helplessly over the frozen keyboard.

He recognized that kind of frustration.

He recognized that kind of quiet panic.

He recognized that exhaustion written in her trembling hands.

He hesitated.

Should I say something?

His heart thudded once.

No...

He took another step but stopped again.

Maybe...

He wasn’t the type to approach strangers easily.

He wasn’t bold.

He wasn’t outgoing.

He kept to himself, always respectful of other people’s space.

But something in Aura’s slumped shoulders tugged at him.

He took a small breath — courage, drawn from somewhere unfamiliar — and approached slowly.

“Um... excuse me,” he said softly.

Aura jerked her head up, startled.

Her eyes widened slightly as she saw him — the boy from the corridor weeks earlier. Not that she remembered him consciously. He had been just another student in a crowd. A passing face. A quiet presence swallowed by noise.

But now, standing before her, he looked different.

Or maybe she was simply looking at him for real this time.

“Yes?” she said, wiping the stress from her voice as best she could.

He stepped closer — carefully, gently, respectfully — leaving enough space not to intrude.

“I saw your screen freeze,” he said, voice gentle but steady. “If you want... I can try to fix it? I’ve helped classmates with this before.”

Aura blinked, processing his offer.

Processing him.

Then she exhaled.

“Please,” she said, handing him the laptop. “I’m desperate.”

He sat down, though he kept a noticeable distance — a quiet sign of his good manners. His fingers moved over the laptop with practiced familiarity, tapping keys with precision, opening a few hidden menus, checking system responses.

Aura watched him from the side, trying not to stare but unable to look away entirely.

She noticed:

how focused his expression was

how calm he seemed, even under pressure

how gentle his fingers were as they worked

how he didn't fidget or show off

how he moved with clarity and purpose

He spoke only once, his voice soft and sure:

“Your system froze during auto-save. I'll restore it.”

It took only a few minutes — but to Aura, it felt like an eternity.

Then the screen flickered.

Restarted.

Loaded.

And the slides appeared exactly as she left them.

Aura gasped softly.

Her shoulders dropped in relief.

Her eyes brightened with disbelief.

“You... you fixed it,” she breathed.

He nodded as if it were trivial. “Yeah. It just needed a forced reset.”

Aura let out a long, shaky breath she didn't know she'd been holding.

Then she smiled.

Not a polite smile.

Not a forced smile.

A genuine, warm, grateful smile — the kind of smile that had weight and glow and softness.

“Thank you,” she said quietly. “Really. I don't know what I would've done if I lost all of this.”

He stood quickly, almost embarrassed by how sincere her gratitude was.

“It's no problem,” he replied, voice shy.

He hesitated, then added:

“If it happens again... you can come find me. I don't mind helping.”

Aura opened her mouth, about to ask something — but he took a step back, preparing to leave.

“Wait!” she called.

He paused.

“What's your name?”

He told her.

A name Aura didn't know then would become important.

A name she would replay in her mind one day.

A name she would whisper into her pillow much later in her life.

She repeated it in her thoughts.

He gave a small nod and walked away, disappearing into the hallway before she could say anything else.

Aura stared at her screen, but her mind wasn't on the laptop anymore.

Something lingered in the air — faint, unspoken, forming slowly like a small sunrise behind clouds.

The first connection had been made.

Not dramatic.

Not romantic.

Just real.

And sometimes real is the beginning of everything.

CHAPTER 6: Slow-Burning Familiarity

After that day, something subtle began to shift.

Nothing dramatic.

No sudden friendship.

No exchanged numbers.

No heart-fluttering confessions.

But the universe...

It has a way of arranging small moments with quiet precision.

And so they began appearing near each other — not often enough to be obvious, but often enough that the feeling of coincidence slowly changed into something else. Fate isn't loud. It whispers. It nudges. Aura and the boy she now knew by name were slowly being nudged toward one another.

A Familiar Presence Among Strangers

It started in the cafeteria line. Aura stood with her tray, half-asleep and craving food after a long morning of classes. Then she felt a gentle awareness — a soft intuition that someone familiar was nearby. She glanced sideways. There he was. Standing behind her.

Quiet, composed, looking at the menu board. He didn't speak. He didn't interrupt her thoughts. He just nodded slightly when she noticed him. Aura nodded back, a small curve lifting her lips. Neither of them thought much of it. Yet something warm lingered. Next, it was the library. Aura sat between tall shelves of textbooks, tapping her pen against her notebook with that little rhythmic pattern she always did when thinking deeply. He passed by with two thick reference books in his arms, glancing at her briefly.

No words.

But there was something in the exchange — a tiny recognition. Like seeing someone you don't know, but knowing them somehow.

Then it was the stairs. Aura was coming down. He was going up. They stepped aside for each other at the same time, then paused in a small awkward dance of politeness.

“Sorry,” Aura said softly.

“It's okay,” he replied, stepping back to let her pass.

She walked away with an unexplainable flutter in her stomach. He walked away with a small, unfamiliar warmth.

The Things He Noticed

He hadn't meant to observe her. He wasn't trying to. But Aura drew attention in the way sunlight draws warmth — naturally, quietly, without meaning to. He began noticing small things — She always ordered sweet iced tea. She tapped her pen when she concentrated. She had a habit of smiling politely at strangers. She walked slightly faster than most people. She looked tired sometimes, but pretended she wasn't. She carried an air of determination that made her seem stronger than she felt.

He admired her from a careful distance — not wanting to intrude, not wanting to make assumptions.

He didn't know why he noticed these things.

He only knew that he did.

The Things She Noticed

Aura didn't realize it at first, but slowly she began to notice him too. It wasn't his height or his face or his voice. It was his presence. He had a calm aura — grounding, balanced, stable. She noticed how:

he always carried textbooks tucked neatly against his side
his steps were quiet, like he didn't want to disturb the world
he never pushed or rushed in crowds
he nodded politely at professors
he focused deeply, as if everything he did mattered
he seemed gentle, even in silence

He was always “there” — not in her way, not following her, just existing in the same spaces at the same times. Like a silent coincidence. A gentle pattern. A quiet constant. Aura wasn't sure what to do with that feeling. She wasn't used to noticing people so closely. But she couldn't deny it — she noticed him.

The Courtyard Evening

One evening, the sky was washed in soft orange — the kind of sunset that makes shadows stretch long and everything glow slightly. Aura walked across the courtyard after a tiring day. She rubbed her neck, feeling knots of stress tangled beneath her skin.

Then she saw him.

He was sitting alone on a bench beneath a tree, earbuds in, studying silently. The golden light softened the lines of his face, giving him a gentle, almost peaceful look.

Aura slowed.

Just a little.

Just enough.

He helped me once...

Should I say thank you again?

The thought crossed her mind softly, like a shy breeze.

She took two steps toward him but stopped.

Her throat tightened.

Her heart beat faster than she expected.

Not yet, she told herself.

So she walked past him — but her steps unconsciously softened, slowed, careful not to disturb the moment.

He looked up at that exact second.

Their eyes didn't meet.

Not fully.

But he saw her, walking past in the glow of sunset.

And something warm settled in his chest — something quiet, something new.

Two People, Not Close... Yet Closer Than Before

They weren't friends.

They weren't anything defined.

They hadn't exchanged numbers, or stories, or pieces of their hearts.

But something was forming.

A delicate familiarity.

A small connection.

A gentle awareness.

The kind that grows slowly... like warmth creeping into cold hands.

Two people, moving quietly toward a future neither could see yet.

Two stories beginning to weave themselves together.

Not loudly.

Not abruptly.

But softly.

As all slow-burn beginnings do.

CHAPTER 7 — Between Fire and Earth

Days slipped by gently, almost without being noticed. One morning became another, and then another, until a whole month seemed to have passed like a quiet breeze moving through an open room. Nothing big happened between Aura and him — no dramatic confessions, no sudden moments that changed everything in one breath. But small things happened, and those small things began to matter.

It started with simple habits. When Aura walked into the common room and saw him there, her feet naturally carried her toward him. She didn't think about it. She didn't force it. It just felt right. And when he looked up and noticed her coming closer, something in his face softened, like a curtain letting in more light.

Their connection wasn't loud. It wasn't the kind of story that made other people stop and stare. It was quiet, warm, careful — the kind of bond that grows slowly but stays strong.

Quiet Moments

Some days they studied together, sitting at the same long wooden table in the library. Aura liked the sound of his typing. It was steady and calm, like a heartbeat that never rushed. She liked how he sat — straight, focused, but never tense. When she felt her own thoughts racing too fast, she found herself looking at him, and somehow she calmed down again.

Sometimes he would glance at her too. His eyes didn't stay on her long, only for a second, but that second always carried something gentle. Sometimes he gave a small smile, and Aura felt it linger in her chest longer than she expected.

They didn't always talk. In fact, many of their hours together were silent. But it wasn't uncomfortable. Their silence felt safe, as if the space between them was filled with an unspoken promise that neither of them needed to explain.

Other times they shared simple conversations — small stories about childhood, complaints about group projects, jokes about teachers who talked too fast. Aura found herself laughing more around him, even when his jokes were not really jokes but honest thoughts spoken in a plain, straightforward way. Something about his simplicity made her feel lighter.

A Shift They Didn't Name

Even though no one said it out loud, something was changing. Their classmates noticed too. Once, during a group study session, Aura had walked into the room and sat beside him without thinking. Another student raised an eyebrow, then looked away politely. Aura felt her cheeks grow warm, but he didn't seem bothered. He simply shifted a little to make space for her notebook.

Another time, during lunch, he brought her an extra water bottle without asking. "You forgot yours today," he said. "How did you know?" Aura asked, surprised. "You always bring one," he said, "and today you came in with empty hands."

It wasn't a big thing. It wasn't a confession. But Aura felt something flutter quietly inside her, like a small bird testing its wings.

A Long Afternoon

One late afternoon, they sat together in the library. The room was almost empty because most students had gone to dinner. Sunlight faded slowly through the tall windows, painting thin golden lines across the floor.

Aura stretched her arms above her head and let out a small sigh. She was tired from reading long articles that made her brain feel heavy. When she looked over at him, he was already watching her — not staring, just noticing.

“Long day?” he asked softly.

“Long week,” Aura laughed.

He smiled at that, a real smile that reached his eyes. Then he closed the book in front of him, as if deciding it was time for a break.

“What do you want to do after graduation?” he asked.

Aura blinked. The question was simple, but the way he asked it — steady, curious, gentle — made it feel much deeper. It wasn’t a question just for fun. It was a question that asked her to open herself.

She leaned back in her chair and looked up at the ceiling for a moment. “I want to travel,” she said. “I want to see other countries. Maybe work somewhere abroad. I just... want a life where I’m not only trying to survive.”

She paused, letting her own words settle.

“I want something bigger than the life I have now,” she added quietly.

He didn’t look surprised. He didn’t judge her. He didn’t laugh at her dreams. Instead, he listened with his full attention, as if every word she said was important.

“You want freedom,” he said.

Aura nodded. “Yes. Freedom. And new experiences. New places. New people.”

He lowered his eyes for a second, thinking. “I understand.”

Then Aura asked, “What about you?”

He hesitated, rubbing the back of his thumb along the edge of his notebook, a habit he had whenever he felt shy about sharing something personal.

“I want something stable,” he said finally. “A job I can keep. A family I can take care of. A life where I know the people I love are safe.”

His voice wasn’t loud, but it carried weight. He spoke like someone who had lived around fear or worry. Aura’s eyes softened. She didn’t know the details of his past, but she didn’t need to. She could feel the truth in the way he said it.

“You want peace,” Aura said gently.

He nodded. “Yes. Peace. And... something steady. Something I can depend on.”

For a long moment, neither of them spoke. The sunlight outside faded until only a soft golden glow remained. Aura looked at him — really looked — and something clicked inside her that she had never noticed before.

Her fire.

His earth.

She was always moving, always dreaming, always wanting to break free.
He was steady, grounded, thoughtful, wanting safety and strong roots.

Two very different people.

Two very different dreams.

And yet... they didn’t feel opposite. They felt like two halves of something whole.

Small Steps Forward

After that day, things between them changed in tiny ways.

When they walked side by side, their shoulders sometimes brushed. Not on purpose, but not by accident either.

When they studied, he started bringing her small snacks. Nothing fancy — a cookie, a pack of crackers, a slice of fruit. “I wasn’t sure if you ate,” he would say in his soft voice. Aura always smiled and took it.

He began sharing more about himself too — small things, like how he liked waking up early because the world felt calmer at dawn, or how he used to take care of his younger cousins, or how he always double-checked locks before going to bed because he wanted everyone to feel safe.

Aura told him about her dreams of cities she’d only seen in videos — Tokyo, Paris, Seoul. She told him about her fear of becoming stuck in a life that felt too small. She told him about the night sky she used to watch from her rooftop when she felt lonely.

Sometimes, while she talked, he watched her the way people watch a small flame — with care, with curiosity, and with a little bit of awe.

A Walk Under Fading Light

One evening, they left the library together because the campus lights had already turned on. The sky was dark blue, almost purple, with a thin crescent moon hanging above the buildings.

They didn’t rush. The path was quiet, lined by tall trees. The air smelled faintly of grass and cold night wind.

Aura walked slightly ahead, swinging her bag lightly with each step. He walked beside her, hands in his pockets, his steps steady and calm.

“Do you ever think about the future too much?” Aura asked suddenly.

“All the time,” he admitted.

“Does it scare you?”

“Yes,” he said. “But not because I expect something bad. It scares me because I’m not sure how to protect the people I care about.”

Aura slowed her steps. “You think a lot about other people.”

He shrugged a little. “Someone should.”

She looked at him for a moment, studying the gentle shape of his face in the dim light. “You have a good heart,” she said softly.

He didn’t answer. He didn’t know what to do with praise; it always made him shy. But Aura saw the way his ears turned slightly red.

They reached the dorm entrance, and for a moment they just stood there, unsure if they should say goodbye or keep talking. The silence stretched between them, warm and full.

“Goodnight,” he said first.

“Goodnight,” Aura said. But she didn’t walk inside right away.

He paused. “Are you okay?”

“Yes,” she said. “Just... thinking.”

“About what?”

“About how different we are,” she said with a small laugh.

He smiled, slow and tender. “Yeah. We are.”

“Do you think that’s bad?”

He shook his head. “No. I think it means we can learn from each other.”

Aura felt something melt softly inside her, like ice touched by morning sun.

Fire and Earth

That night, when she lay on her bed staring at the ceiling, Aura thought about the way he spoke, the way he listened, the way he cared without asking for anything in return. She thought about his dreams — steady, simple, full of responsibility — and how different they were from her wild, wandering ones.

She wondered if two people with such different hearts could ever walk the same road.

But then she remembered how natural it felt whenever they were side by side. How her restless energy seemed to quiet near him. How his calmness seemed a little brighter near her. How their differences didn’t pull them apart; they shaped something new.

Her fire didn’t burn him.

His earth didn’t trap her.

They balanced.

Maybe fate saw it too — the way they moved toward each other without meaning to. The way their dreams didn't match but their souls did.

Maybe the stars were watching, writing their story little by little, waiting to see what they would become.

Something was beginning.

Something gentle.

Something real.

And neither of them, not even Aura with all her dreams, could predict where it would lead.

CHAPTER 8 — Under One Umbrella

Their real interactions started in the most natural way — not planned, not forced, just a quiet pull that kept drawing them closer. Neither of them could say exactly when it began. Maybe it was the way she always smiled when she saw him. Maybe it was the way he listened more carefully when she spoke. Or maybe it was simply the universe gently pushing them toward each other, step by step.

It happened on a rainy afternoon.

The sky had turned dark hours earlier, heavy clouds rolling in like a thick curtain. Most students hurried indoors, clutching their jackets and umbrellas. Aura hadn't been so lucky. Her umbrella had snapped backward in a strong gust of wind, bending into a useless, broken shape. Now she sat under the covered walkway behind the main building, hugging her knees as she waited for the rain to slow. Droplets hit the pavement in loud patterns, forming small rivers that rushed toward the drainage grate.

Aura sighed heavily. She didn't mind rain itself. She actually liked the sound of it — calm, rhythmic, soothing. But she hated being stuck without a way home.

She leaned her head against the cool wall behind her and pulled out her phone. No messages. No missed calls. She thought briefly about running through the rain like a dramatic movie scene, but then imagined herself slipping and falling like a badly acted comedy instead.

So, she waited.

A few meters away, he walked out of the library, umbrella in hand. He opened it smoothly and stepped into the rain. He was focused on the ground at first, carefully avoiding puddles. Then, out of the corner of his eye, he saw someone sitting alone under the walkway.

Aura.

He stopped walking.

He wasn't sure if he should go over. Part of him worried she might not want company. Another part of him — the part that always noticed her, even in a crowded room — wanted to ask if she was okay. He stood still for a moment, rain tapping steadily on his umbrella as he debated with himself.

Finally, he took a deep breath and walked toward her.

Aura was too lost in her own thoughts to notice him right away. She only looked up when she heard footsteps stop near her. When she saw him standing there, rainwater gathering around his shoes, her eyes widened a little in surprise.

“You didn't bring an umbrella?” he asked.

Aura gave a dramatic sigh. “Mine died. A tragic death.”

He blinked. “...Your umbrella died?”

“It turned inside out,” she explained, waving her hand like she was telling a sad story. “It gave up on life.”

He simply stared at her for a second, not sure how to respond to her dramatic storytelling. Then, without a word, he held out his umbrella toward her.

“Let's walk.”

Aura straightened. “What? No. Then you'll get wet.”

“I don’t mind.”

But she minded. Or rather, she didn’t understand why he would willingly get soaked just to help her.

“You’re going to freeze,” she said, raising an eyebrow.

He shook his head. “I’ll be fine. Come on.”

Something about his steady voice, quiet but firm, made Aura stand up. She wasn’t used to people insisting on helping her. She wasn’t used to someone choosing to be uncomfortable just so she wouldn’t be.

She blinked at him, then slowly stepped beside him under the umbrella.

Fire met earth — her warm, restless spirit brushing against his calm, grounded presence.

They began walking.

The rain around them made everything feel smaller, almost like the world had narrowed into a private space just for the two of them. He held the umbrella slightly tilted so it covered her more than himself. His right shoulder was getting wet, but he didn’t seem bothered at all.

Aura noticed immediately.

“Hey, you’re getting soaked.”

“It’s okay.”

“No, it’s not okay,” she said, frowning. “Move closer.”

He hesitated. “But then we’ll be—”

“Just move closer.”

He finally did. Their arms didn’t touch, but they were close enough that Aura felt the warmth of him beside her. She wondered if he could feel the warmth radiating from her too. The air between them felt charged, almost like static electricity.

As they walked, Aura realized something else. He was walking slightly slower than he usually did. She knew his normal pace — steady, quick, purposeful. But now he was matching hers, adjusting without thinking.

The detail touched her more than she expected.

She sneaked a small look at him. He kept his eyes straight ahead, watching the path through the rain. His expression was calm, almost peaceful, as if walking with her felt natural.

Aura bit her lip for a moment, then asked boldly, “Why are you always so quiet?”

He didn’t look at her. “I think before I speak,” he said simply.

She waited. “And what do you think about?”

He paused, just for a second. Aura didn’t expect him to answer — not seriously. She thought he might shrug or change the subject. But instead he said, very softly,

“...a lot of things.”

That could have been the end of it. But then he added, almost in a whisper,

“But lately... you.”

Aura stopped breathing for a second.

Her usual fiery nature wanted to make a joke, tease him, or say something light so she wouldn't melt into the ground. But something about the sincerity in his voice made her stay quiet.

“You notice a lot, huh?” she murmured, her voice a bit softer than before.

He nodded. “I do.”

“And you...” he said, pausing as if choosing his words, “express a lot.”

Aura let out a small laugh. “Am I that obvious?”

“Only when you're frustrated,” he replied. “You wrinkle your nose. And when you're excited, you talk faster. You use your hands a lot too.”

She turned her head sharply to look at him.

He had noticed all of that?

“You pay attention,” she said quietly.

“I try to,” he answered.

The rain continued falling around them, but Aura didn't feel cold anymore. Not with him walking beside her, sharing the same umbrella, noticing details she never knew anyone would see.

They reached the end of the walkway, but neither of them stopped. They kept walking, letting the rain-filled world hold them in its quiet embrace.

Fire and earth.

Different. Opposite in many ways.

But fitting together more than either of them expected.

And as they walked through the rain — shoulders close, steps matched, sharing the same small space of warmth — Aura felt something shift quietly inside her.

Something beginning.

Something real.

Something she was no longer sure she wanted to run away from.

CHAPTER 8.1 — Small Moments, Big Feelings

After the rainy walk, something changed inside Aura — not loudly, not suddenly, but in a quiet way that she couldn't ignore. It felt like a small door had opened in her heart, letting in a warm breeze she wasn't prepared for.

She tried to go on with her normal routine. Classes, notes, assignments, late nights finishing readings she should've started earlier. But no matter what she did, he slipped into her thoughts like a soft echo. Not enough to distract her completely... but enough to make her pulse skip every now and then.

She thought of him at random times:

When she bought iced tea from the vending machine and remembered how he preferred warm drinks, saying they helped him focus.

When she carried heavy books and wondered if he would've quietly offered to take one from her.

When she walked past the big tree in the courtyard—the one they had passed during the rainy walk—and felt a strange warmth in her chest because it reminded her of him.

When she heard footsteps behind her or a soft voice nearby... and found herself hoping, just a little, that it might be him.

Aura wasn't used to this. She wasn't used to thinking of someone this often, especially someone who wasn't loud or flashy or trying to impress her. He didn't chase her attention; he simply existed quietly beside her, and somehow that made her notice him even more.

The Way He Looked at Her

Sometimes, when she glanced up from her desk or turned her head in the hallway, she caught him watching her.

Not staring.

Not intense.

Just aware.

Like the way a person notices the sunlight entering a room through an open window — soft, warm, natural.

Every time it happened, Aura's heart made a small jump. She told herself she was imagining it. She told herself he probably looked at everyone like that

CHAPTER 8.2 — The Almost Touch

As the semester continued, they kept drifting toward each other without trying. It was never planned, yet always happening — a quiet gravity pulling them into the same spaces again and again.

A shared class where they somehow always ended up sitting near each other.

A hallway encounter that felt perfectly timed.

A random moment where they happened to walk out of the same building at the exact same time.

They never talked about it, but both noticed.

One afternoon, they were studying side by side in the library. The room was silent except for the soft hum of the air conditioner and the occasional turning of pages. The large table they shared was almost empty except for their notebooks, pens, and drinks.

Aura was focused on the paragraph in front of her when she decided to reach for her notebook. At that same moment, he reached for his pen.

Their fingers brushed.

Just barely.

Just a feather-light touch.

But it stopped both of them instantly.

Aura's breath caught in her throat. A warm shock traveled from her hand all the way up her arm. She pulled her hand back quickly, heat rising to her cheeks.

He reacted even faster. His hand snapped away like he had touched actual fire. His ears turned a deep shade of red, and he stared straight at his book as if it could save him.

For a long moment, neither of them spoken.

The tiny sound of rain outside filled the silence between them. Aura could hear her own heartbeat louder than anything else. She swallowed hard.

Then, without lifting his eyes, he whispered,

“Sorry.”

Aura bit her lip to stop a nervous smile from forming.

“It’s okay,” she whispered back.

But her heart didn’t slow down for a long time.

Her fingers still tingled where they had touched. She looked at him out of the corner of her eye — his face calm, but his posture stiff, like he was trying very hard not to react.

That tiny, accidental moment marked something new between them. A spark.

The first spark neither of them could deny.

CHAPTER 8.3 — When Jealousy First Appeared

The first time Aura saw jealousy in his eyes, it surprised her more than anything else. It happened during class. She was sitting near the front, while he had chosen a seat two rows behind. She didn't expect to talk to anyone that day, but one of her classmates — a friendly boy with a bright smile — leaned over and asked her a question about the assignment.

They chatted for a moment. Aura laughed at something he said — not because she liked him, but because the joke was genuinely funny.

But then she felt something.

A shift.

A quiet tension coming from behind her.

When she glanced back, she saw him. Not staring. Not glaring. Just watching with an expression, she had never seen on him before — jaw slightly tight, eyes a little darker than usual. He looked away quickly and pretended to read his notes, but Aura wasn't fooled. She knew him well enough by now to notice tiny changes. And that tiny change told her everything.

He was jealous.

The realization made something warm bloom inside her chest — unexpected, gentle, and dangerous all at once.

After class, she packed her things slowly, still thinking about the look she'd seen on him. As she stepped outside, she heard footsteps behind her. A moment later, he walked beside her, matching her pace.

“You seemed... happy today,” he said very softly.

Aura blinked at him. His tone wasn’t sharp or suspicious. It was more like he was trying not to sound curious. But Aura could hear every unspoken question:

Who were you smiling at?

Do you like him?

Am I imagining this?

She hid a small smile behind her hair.

“It was just a joke,” she said lightly. “Nothing special.”

He nodded, staring straight ahead. He didn’t ask anything else.

But Aura saw it — the way his shoulders relaxed, the way a tiny breath left his chest. Relief. Quiet, shy, almost invisible. But real.

And for reasons she didn’t want to examine too closely, that warmth inside her grew.

CHAPTER 8.4 — The Day He Waited For Her

Aura stayed late on campus one night. She had a major assignment due the next morning, so she stayed in the computer lab long after everyone else had left. By the time she finally saved her work and packed her things, the sky outside was pitch black.

The walk to the gate suddenly felt longer than usual. The hallways were quiet. The streetlights were faint and scattered, leaving stretches of darkness between them.

She tightened her grip on her bag.

When she reached the gate, she froze.

He was there.

Leaning against a tree just beside the entrance, hands in his pockets, eyes lifted toward the night sky as if he had been waiting for a long time. The soft glow of the streetlamp above him made the scene feel unreal.

“What are you doing here?” Aura asked, her voice small.

He turned immediately at the sound of her voice. His expression—calm but relieved—made her heart flip.

“I noticed your class ended late,” he said quietly. “It’s not safe for you to walk alone at night.”

Aura stared at him, stunned.

“You didn’t have to wait—”

“I wanted to.”

Three simple words.

He didn't say them in a dramatic way. He didn't try to act charming or brave. He said it so simply, so honestly, that Aura felt her breath catch in her chest.

They started walking.

Their hands didn't touch. They didn't walk too close. But Aura felt warm the entire time, even though the night air was cool. Every step felt different — heavier somehow, more meaningful.

He matched his pace with hers. When they passed a darker area, he subtly moved a bit closer, placing himself between her and the shadows without making it obvious. Aura noticed everything.

When they reached her dorm, she turned to him.

“Thank you,” she whispered.

He nodded. “Goodnight.”

“Goodnight,” she said softly.

She watched him walk away until he disappeared around the corner, her heart beating louder than it should.

Later that night, Aura lay in bed staring at the ceiling, unable to sleep.

She replayed the moment again and again:

The way he waited.

The way he stood under the streetlight like he belonged there.

The way he said “I wanted to.”

The way she felt safe beside him.

Her heartbeat betrayed her.

Maybe...

Just maybe...

She was starting to like him.

CHAPTER 8.5 — The Hidden Side of Him

The rain came early that morning — a quiet, steady drizzle that made the entire campus feel softer, sleepier. Aura rushed through the hallway, hugging her books against her chest before they could get soaked. She was earlier than usual, thanks to a sleepless night and too much thinking.

When she walked into the classroom, expecting to be alone, she froze.

He was already there.

Sitting near the window, completely unaware of her presence. His hoodie was still damp at the shoulders from the rain. His hair was a little messy. And most surprising of all — he wasn't reading or typing or scrolling through his phone.

He was drawing.

Aura blinked slowly. She had never seen him draw before. She didn't even know he liked art. He always seemed so calm, so focused on logic and order. Seeing him with a pencil in his hand, leaning over a notebook, felt like discovering a secret room in a house she thought she already knew.

She walked quietly toward him, not wanting to startle him. But the closer she got, the more curious she became. His pencil strokes were quick but careful. Whatever he was drawing, it clearly mattered to him.

Before she could get a clear look, he sensed her presence. His head jerked up. Panic flashed across his eyes. Then, in one quick movement, he snapped the notebook shut and held it against his chest.

Aura blinked.

He had never reacted like that before.

“Good morning,” she said softly.

He cleared his throat. “M–morning.”

“What were you drawing?”

He stiffened. His fingers squeezed the notebook tighter than necessary. His ears were turning pink — a sign she knew very well by now. It meant he was flustered, embarrassed, or both.

“It’s nothing,” he said quickly. “Just... drawing.”

Aura tilted her head. “Can I see?”

The question made him freeze.

She took a small step closer. “You know I won’t laugh.”

He looked down at his shoes, uncertain. She could almost hear the thoughts running through his mind — that his drawings weren’t good enough, that she might judge him, that showing her something so personal felt too vulnerable.

So, she softened her voice.

Aura placed two fingers gently on the notebook he held.

“You can trust me,” she whispered.

For a long moment, he didn’t move. The rain outside tapped lightly against the windows. The classroom stayed quiet and empty except for them.

Finally — slowly — he loosened his grip.

He opened the notebook halfway, hesitated, then opened it fully and turned it toward her.

Aura's eyes widened.

It was her.

Not a perfect drawing, not something that looked like a professional artist created it. But it was detailed. Full of attention. Full of quiet admiration.

Her hair, slightly messy the way she often wore it during study sessions.

Her eyes, focused and bright.

Her posture, leaning forward with determination.

Even the tiny habit she had — resting her chin on her hand while reading — was captured clearly.

Aura felt her heartbeat in her throat.

“You... draw me?” she whispered, barely breathing.

He swallowed hard. “I draw what I notice,” he said softly. “And I notice you... a lot.”

Aura didn't know what to say. Her chest felt warm, almost too full. She wasn't used to someone paying such close attention to her. Not like this. Not with this level of care.

He quickly looked away, cheeks flushing deeper.

“You don't have to like it,” he mumbled. “I know it's not perfect. I just—I didn't mean for you to see—”

“I like it,” Aura said immediately.

She placed her hand gently on top of the notebook he was trying to hide again.

“I really do.”

His shoulders relaxed. His eyes flicked up to meet hers just for a second — but that second felt long and meaningful.

At that moment, something between them changed again.

Their feelings grew roots.

Quiet, deep, strong.

His POV: (The Hidden Side of Him)

He came to class early on purpose.

He told himself it was because he needed a quiet place to think, or because he wanted to review his notes. But the truth was simpler — mornings were peaceful, and he liked the calm. He also liked that sometimes Aura arrived early too.

Not that he would ever admit that.

The rain outside made the room feel warmer, softer. He sat near the window, hoodie still damp, and opened his notebook. Drawing wasn't something he told people about. It felt too personal, too exposed. He wasn't amazing at it, but it helped him think. Helped him breathe.

And lately...

he kept drawing the same person.

Aura.

The way she rested her chin on her hand.

The way her hair fell forward when she leaned over a book.

The small determined expression she had when she was concentrating.

He drew her because she stayed on his mind, even when he tried to focus on other things.

He was halfway through sketching the curve of her cheek when he heard footsteps.

Light ones.

Familiar ones.

His chest tightened.

Aura.

Before he could even process it, she was standing near him. He snapped the notebook shut instantly, heat rushing up his neck.

“Good morning,” she said, voice soft.

He wished his heart would stop beating so fast.

“Morning,” he managed.

She tilted her head. “What were you drawing?”

He looked down, embarrassed. “Nothing. Just... drawing.”

But when she asked, “Can I see?” something inside him panicked.

No one had seen his drawings.

No one knew how much he noticed.

No one knew they were all her.

She stepped closer, gentle but sure, and placed her fingers softly on the notebook.

“You can trust me.”

Her voice made his breath catch.

Trust her?

He already did.

More than he ever intended to.

His hands trembled a little as he opened the notebook. He couldn’t look at her face — he was too scared of what he might see there.

But when she finally saw the sketch, she didn’t laugh.

She didn’t tease.

She didn’t pull away.

She looked... touched.

“You... draw me?” she whispered.

His throat tightened. “I draw what I notice,” he said quietly. “And I notice you... a lot.”

Saying it out loud made his ears burn.

He waited for her to say something — anything — but the silence stretched until he felt sure he'd ruined everything.

“You don't have to like it,” he muttered, looking away.

But then she said, softly, warmly,

“I do. I really do.”

Her words sank into him like sunlight through clouds. Unexpected. Gentle. Real.

And for the first time, he let himself wonder if the feelings he carried quietly, carefully, secretly...
might not be one-sided anymore.”

CHAPTER 8.6 — The Way He Watches Over Her

The library was unusually quiet that night. Aura spread her papers and books across the table, forming a small chaotic island of notes, pens, and half-done assignments. Her iced tea was already melting into weak, watery sweetness, but she hardly noticed.

She was tired — the kind of tired that made her eyes blur and her brain slow down. But the deadline was close, and she had no choice but to push through.

From across the room, he sat at a separate table, pretending to study.

Aura didn't know he was there at first. She was too buried in work. But he had noticed her the moment she walked in. He had watched her struggle to carry too many papers, watched her drop her pen twice, watched her sigh a silent, frustrated sigh before finally sitting down.

He wanted to go to her, but he hesitated. He didn't want to distract her. Didn't want to make her uncomfortable, so he sat far enough not to interrupt but close enough to watch over her.

Every few minutes, his eyes drifted to her.

Not in a strange way.

Not in a way that crossed boundaries.

But with quiet concern.

He noticed how she pressed her fingers against her temples when a headache started. How she rubbed her eyes slowly, trying to stay awake. How her shoulders tightened whenever she reread the same sentence three times.

And finally, when he saw her collapse against the table for a moment, exhausted, he stood up.

Aura didn't notice him leave. She was too focused on forcing her brain to keep going. When he returned, she only realized someone was beside her when a warm cup gently touched the edge of her notebook.

Aura looked up, startled.

He stood there, holding the cup he had just placed next to her — warm milk tea, steam rising faintly.

“You looked tired,” he said quietly. “Drink something warm.”

Aura stared at the cup, then at him. Something inside her chest tightened in the gentlest way.

“You didn't have to...” she began.

“I know,” he said. “But I wanted to.”

That answer.

Those words.

They struck her deeper than she expected.

“Thank you,” Aura whispered.

He nodded once, shyly. “Get some rest. Don't overwork yourself.”

Then he returned to his table.

But he never opened his book again.

His eyes stayed on her — not constantly, not obviously — just enough to make sure she was okay. Enough to make sure she drank the tea. Enough to make sure she didn't fall asleep face-first into her notes.

Aura's heart warmed every time she caught him pretending not to watch her.

He wasn't guarding her like a hero from a movie. He wasn't acting bold or dramatic. He was simply being himself — quiet, gentle, protective in a way that felt real.

And Aura, sitting under the warm glow of the library lamp, realized something important:

He cared.

Deeply.

Quietly.

Unselfishly.

More than he ever said out loud.

And with every small moment — every gesture, every look, every soft word — Aura felt her own feelings deepen.

She wasn't ready to say it.

Not yet.

But she felt it growing.

Something warm.

Something tender.

Something she didn't want to run away from anymore.

Their story was no longer just small sparks.

It was becoming a slow-burning flame.

CHAPTER 8.7: The Weight He Carried, The Shoulder She Borrowed

Aura hadn't meant to carry so many books at once.

But the professor had assigned a long reading list, and Aura had decided — in a burst of motivation — to borrow every book she could find before someone else grabbed them. Now she was halfway down the staircase, the stack pressed tightly against her chest, her bag slipping off her shoulder every few seconds, her steps wobbly as she tried not to fall.

Every few steps, she stopped to adjust her grip.

Every few stops, the books threatened to slip.

He saw it the moment he stepped into the hallway.

At first, he thought she was just passing by. Then he noticed her struggle — the way she leaned slightly to one side, the way her elbow tried to nudge her bag up, the way her fingers tightened around the heavy stack.

Something inside him reacted instantly.

He didn't call her name.

He didn't think twice.

He just walked toward her, each step steady and certain.

Before she even reached the bottom of the stairs, he stepped in front of her and gently took the entire stack of books from her arms.

Aura blinked in surprise, relieved but embarrassed. “You don’t have to—”

“I know,” he said softly.

“But I want to.”

Those four words melted her defenses faster than sunshine on ice.

His voice carried no pressure, no sense of “I’m doing this for attention.” It was simply honest — and that honesty warmed her more than she expected.

He shifted the books easily, as if they weighed nothing. Aura followed him through the hallway, watching his calm posture, the way he held everything securely without stumbling once. When they reached her classroom, he pushed the door open and waited for her to walk inside first.

Aura smiled at him — small, grateful, genuinely touched. “Thank you.”

He immediately looked away, ears pink. “It’s nothing.”

But it wasn’t nothing.

Carrying her books made his chest feel strangely full — proud, warm, hopeful. A quiet part of him liked being someone she could rely on, even in small ways.

As Aura settled into her seat, she kept thinking about the look on his face when she thanked him — shy, but secretly pleased.

If only she knew how long that moment stayed inside his mind.

The Study Session

A few days later, their group gathered in the student lounge for a long study session. Exams were close, and everyone was stressed. Aura tried to keep up, flipping through her notes with a tired sigh. She had slept late the night before — again — and her eyes kept growing heavier with every page.

He sat beside her, close enough to help if she needed it but far enough not to distract her. He noticed everything: the slow blinking, the drooping posture, the way her chin kept slipping from her hand.

She was exhausted.

“Take a break,” he whispered.

Aura shook her head. “I’m fine.”

She wasn’t.

Minutes passed. The room filled with quiet discussions and scratching pens. Aura leaned back to stretch her neck. She didn’t realize how tired she was... until her head gently tipped sideways.

And landed on his shoulder.

At first, she didn’t notice.

But he did.

His entire world stopped.

The pencil in his hand froze mid-air. His spine straightened. His breath caught. His heart pounded so loudly he was sure the entire room could hear it. Heat rushed to his face so quickly it almost hurt.

Aura's head rested lightly against him, her hair brushing his collarbone, her breathing soft and calm. She wasn't fully asleep — just resting — but her body trusted him enough to relax.

He didn't dare move.

If he shifted even a little, she might wake up. She might pull away. She might apologize. And he didn't want any of that.

So he stayed still.

Minutes passed.

Five.

Ten.

Fifteen.

His shoulder grew stiff. A gentle ache formed near his neck. Soreness spread down his arm. But none of it mattered. Having her close, even by accident, made everything else fade.

He didn't try to memorize the moment, but it engraved itself into him anyway — the warmth of her weight, the softness of her hair, the trust in her relaxed expression.

And the dangerous thought that whispered inside him:

I wish I could stay like this longer.

When She Realized

Eventually, Aura blinked herself awake. She shifted slightly — then froze when she realized where her head had been resting.

Her eyes widened. She sat up so fast she nearly knocked her notebook off the table.

“Oh my god— sorry!” she whispered harshly, mortified.

He shook his head quickly, as if the apology didn’t make sense to him. “It’s okay.”

She looked at him, still flustered. Her cheeks were warm with embarrassment. His were warm for a completely different reason.

He swallowed once, then added quietly,

“You can... lean on me if you're tired.”

Aura’s breath caught.

She didn’t lean again that day — too shy, too aware, too shaken by how natural it had felt. But the moment replayed in her head long after the study session ended.

The weight of her books he carried so easily.

The warmth of his shoulder she borrowed without thinking.

The gentle tone in his voice when he told her she could rest on him.

The way he froze — not in fear, but in something tender, careful, full of longing he never dared express.

That night, Aura lay in bed with her pillow pulled close, replaying everything.

His instinct to protect her.

His willingness to carry her burdens.

His stillness when she leaned on him.

The soft red on his ears.

The soft truth in his eyes.

Something inside her was shifting too — slow, warm, and impossible to ignore.

She was starting to see him differently.

Not just as someone kind.

Not just as someone patient.

Not just as someone steady.

But as someone whose presence felt safe...

someone whose quiet care felt beautiful...

someone whose shoulder she wanted to lean on again...

on purpose.

CHAPTER9: When I Started Noticing My Own Heart

I didn't mean for it to happen.

I wasn't looking for anything. I wasn't waiting for anyone. I told myself I was fine on my own — busy, moving forward, dreaming about places far away. Feelings were never supposed to slow me down.

And yet... here I am.

Somewhere along the way, he became part of my days in a way I didn't plan. Not loudly. Not suddenly. Just quietly — like a habit I didn't realize I was forming until it was already there.

I notice him in small ways now.

When I walk into a room, my eyes look for him before I even think about it.

When I sit down, I feel calmer if he's nearby.

When something good happens, I almost turn to tell him — then stop myself.

That's when I know something is changing.

I tell myself it's nothing serious. He's kind. He's steady. Anyone would feel comfortable around him. Anyone would feel safe.

Safe.

That word lingers longer than I expect.

I've always been the kind of person who keeps moving — forward, outward, away. I don't like feeling tied down. I don't like needing someone too much. Independence has always been my shield.

But with him... I don't feel trapped.

I feel grounded.

Sometimes I catch him watching me — not staring, not intense — just quietly aware. And instead of feeling uncomfortable, I feel seen. Like someone is paying attention to the parts of me that usually go unnoticed.

That scares me a little.

Because being seen means being known.
And being known means being vulnerable.

I laugh easily around him. I talk more than usual. I complain, I joke, I let my guard down in ways I don't always realize until later. And when I think about it at night, lying in bed with my thoughts too loud to ignore, I wonder:

When did he start feeling this familiar?

I don't know what I feel yet. I really don't. I just know that when he's quiet, I want to fill the silence. When he's near, my steps slow down. When he isn't around, something feels slightly off — like I forgot something important.

And then there's the part I don't want to think about.

Other people.

I talk to classmates. I laugh at jokes. I smile without meaning anything by it. That's just who I am — friendly, open, expressive.

But lately, I catch myself wondering...

Does he see this?

Does he think something of it?

The thought surprises me.

Why would I care?

I tell myself I don't. I tell myself I'm imagining things. But deep down, there's a small, quiet awareness growing — a feeling I haven't named yet, but can't ignore either.

I don't belong to him.

He doesn't belong to me.

And yet...

Somewhere inside me, something is shifting. Something warm. Something unsure. Something that makes my chest tighten just a little when I think about the way he looks at me — careful, steady, like he's holding something fragile.

Like me.

I don't know where this is going.

But I know one thing now.

Whatever this feeling is...

It's no longer just comfort.

And soon — very soon — I have a feeling I'll see how much it truly matters.

CHAPTER 8.9.1 — When I Didn't Know I Was the Reason

I didn't think anything of it at first.

We had just finished a group meeting — one of those long, tiring ones where everyone talked too much and decided too little. When it finally ended, there was that familiar feeling of relief, like a tight knot loosening in the chest. People stood around in small clusters, stretching, complaining, laughing softly.

I stayed with a few classmates near the hallway.

Someone — one of the boys from the group — said something silly. Not clever, not meaningful, just one of those harmless comments people make when they're done pretending to be serious. I laughed without thinking.

It wasn't loud.

It wasn't forced.

Just a small laugh that came out easily.

For a moment, I felt light.

The boy smiled, encouraged, and kept talking. I nodded, brushing a loose strand of hair behind my ear. Everything felt normal. Comfortable. Ordinary.

And then something shifted.

I don't know how to explain it — there was no sound, no obvious movement. Just a feeling, sudden and quiet, like the air itself had changed weight.

I became aware of myself.

Of how I was standing.

Of my smile.

Of the way my laughter faded just a second slower than usual.

I looked up.

And that's when I saw him.

He had just turned the corner at the end of the hallway.

He didn't freeze dramatically. He didn't react in any obvious way. If someone else had been watching, they might not have noticed anything at all. He simply stopped walking — just slightly — as if he had forgotten where he was going.

From where I stood, it looked like he pulled out his phone and leaned against the wall.

Casual.

Normal.

But I knew him well enough now to feel it.

Something was wrong.

His posture was too still. His shoulders held a quiet tension I had never seen before. He wasn't angry — I knew that. He wasn't the type. There was no sharpness in him, no outward frustration.

What I felt instead was something restrained.

Contained.

Like he was holding something inside his chest and refusing to let it show.

My laughter faded completely.

The boy next to me kept talking, unaware. I nodded again, trying to follow the conversation, but my attention drifted. My eyes kept pulling back toward him, even when I told myself not to stare.

He didn't look at me directly.

Not fully.

But his eyes lifted — just briefly — then dropped again. Like he didn't trust himself to look for too long.

My stomach tightened.

Why did that make my chest feel strange?

I told myself I was imagining things. That he was probably tired. Distracted. Thinking about something else. He always thought deeply; that was nothing new.

Still... something felt different.

The boy beside me leaned in slightly as he spoke again, lowering his voice like he was sharing a secret. I smiled politely. I laughed softly again — but this time, the sound felt thinner, less real.

Out of habit, my fingers touched my hair, smoothing it back.

And I saw it.

Not clearly — not like a dramatic scene in a movie — but clearly enough to feel it.

He looked away.

Quickly.

Like the sight in front of him had become too much.

A strange pull settled in my chest, uncomfortable and confusing. I didn't know why it mattered. I didn't know why my smile felt heavier now, or why the conversation suddenly felt like something I wanted to escape.

The boy's hand brushed lightly against my elbow as he spoke — friendly, thoughtless, harmless.

And in that same moment, I saw him turn his head completely away.

Something inside me dropped.

I excused myself not long after. My voice was calm, my smile polite, but my thoughts were tangled. I walked away from the group with a strange tightness in my chest, glancing back once before I reached the stairs.

He was gone.

The hallway felt emptier than it should have.

The rest of the day felt... off.

Nothing else went wrong. My classes went fine. People talked to me. I answered. I smiled when needed. But there was a quiet distraction following me, like a shadow I couldn't shake.

I kept replaying the moment in my head.

The way he stood there.

The way he looked away.

The feeling that something delicate had been touched without my meaning to.

Had I done something wrong?

The thought annoyed me.

I hadn't done anything inappropriate. I hadn't flirted. I hadn't crossed any lines. Laughing wasn't a crime. Talking to classmates wasn't betrayal.

So why did it feel like I had unsettled something?

That evening, I sat on my bed with my laptop open, pretending to focus on an assignment. My phone rested beside me, silent.

I picked it up.

Put it down.

Picked it up again.

I typed a message to him — something small. Casual. A simple thought about the meeting earlier, a light comment, nothing emotional. The kind of message we sent each other all the time.

I stared at the screen before sending it, hesitating for reasons I didn't understand.

Finally, I hit send.

The reply didn't come right away.

That wasn't unusual — he was often busy, often thoughtful before responding. But tonight, the silence stretched longer than usual.

I told myself not to check the time.

I checked it anyway.

When his reply finally arrived, it was normal.

Kind.

Polite.

Him.

But it was slower.

Something about the timing — the pause — sat oddly in my chest. I reread the message more than once, searching for something that wasn't there.

Why did that bother me?

I sighed and set the phone down, annoyed with myself.

I didn't want to be this person. The kind who overthinks. The kind who reads into pauses and silence. I had always been open, expressive, unafraid of connections.

So why did this feel different?

I lay back on my pillow, staring at the ceiling.

Images drifted through my mind.

His shoulder under my head.

His arm around me under the tree.

The way he opened space for me without words.

A thought surfaced, soft but unsettling:

What if I matter to him more than I realized?

The idea made my chest tighten.

Not because it was unwanted.

But because it was heavy with responsibility.

I turned onto my side, hugging my pillow close.

I still didn't have a word for what had passed between us that afternoon.

I didn't know what he had felt.

I didn't know what I had stirred.

All I knew was that something quiet had shifted — something fragile, something unspoken — and neither of us had reached for it yet.

Not tonight.

But soon.

And somehow, deep down, I sensed that whatever this was...
it wouldn't stay silent for much longer.

CHAPTER 8.9.2 — The Day She Was Surrounded by Boys

Aura stood near the front of the classroom, her bag resting at her feet, her notebook open but untouched. The teacher was late — again — and the room buzzed with restless energy. Chairs scraped softly against the floor. Voices overlapped in casual conversation.

She wasn't alone for long.

Three male classmates gathered around her desk, one after another, drawn in by convenience at first — questions about the assignment, about deadlines, about which chapter would be on the quiz. Aura answered politely, as she always did, her voice calm, her expression open but reserved.

They laughed easily.

She smiled when appropriate.

Nodded.

Explained.

I'm just being helpful, she thought. That's all this is.

One of the boys leaned back against a desk, another rested his elbow on the table near her notebook. Nothing inappropriate. Nothing obvious. Just closeness — the kind that happens without intention.

Still, Aura felt oddly aware of herself.

Of the space around her.

Of how near they were standing.

Of how long the conversation was lasting.

Then the door opened.

He walked in with his backpack slung over one shoulder, steps steady, expression neutral. At first, he didn't slow — until he saw her.

Surrounded.

He stopped a few steps away.

Not abruptly.

Not dramatically.

Just enough.

From where Aura stood, she felt the shift before she fully understood it. Something in the room changed — subtle, quiet, but unmistakable.

She looked up.

Their eyes met.

And instantly, her expression softened.

“Hey,” she said, without thinking.

Her voice was different when she spoke to him — she noticed that now. Gentler. Warmer. Like she didn't need to perform.

He nodded in response. Just once.

But his eyes moved.

Not to her face — not right away.

To the boys.

Careful.

Measured.

Observing.

It wasn't anger that crossed his features.

It was analysis.

Who are they?

Why are they so close?

Do they always stand like this around her?

Are they flirting — or am I imagining it?

Aura saw his jaw tighten slightly, just for a moment. So quickly she might have missed it if she hadn't learned his quiet tells.

One of the boys laughed loudly, slapping the table near Aura as he finished a joke. The sound echoed a little too sharply in the room.

Aura smiled politely, out of habit.

Why do I suddenly feel uncomfortable? she wondered.

He didn't step forward.

He didn't interrupt.

He didn't say her name.

He just stayed.

Close enough to be noticed.

Close enough to be felt.

Aura became acutely aware of his presence — like a warm shadow at her back. He wasn't touching her, wasn't claiming space loudly, but somehow the air around him carried a quiet message.

She felt it settle around her shoulders like an invisible coat.

He's here.

The boys noticed it too — not immediately, but gradually. Their laughter softened. Their bodies shifted slightly, instinctively making space. One of them glanced toward him, then back at Aura, then cleared his throat.

Another checked his phone.

One by one, they drifted away — not rushed, not offended — just... aware.

Aware that something had changed.

That Aura was not alone.

He hadn't said a word.

Hadn't raised his voice.

Hadn't claimed anything aloud.

But there was something protective in the way he stood there — something quiet and solid that said enough without speaking.

Aura watched the last boy leave, confusion settling gently into her chest.

When the space around her finally cleared, she turned to him.

He was still standing there, hands loose at his sides, expression carefully neutral.

“Were you... waiting?” she asked.

Her voice was soft. Curious. Not accusing.

He shook his head slightly. “No.”

A pause.

“I was just... here.”

The words were casual. Almost careless.

But his eyes betrayed him.

They lingered on her a second longer than necessary, searching her face — not for guilt, not for explanation — but for reassurance he hadn’t asked for.

You stayed, she realized.

You didn’t walk away.

Something warm bloomed in her chest, unexpected and tender.

“Oh,” she said quietly, not knowing what else to say.

The teacher finally entered the room, breaking the moment. Chairs moved again. Voices returned. Aura sat down, her heart a little louder than before.

As she opened her notebook, she felt his presence nearby — not beside her, but close enough to matter.

And the thought came, uninvited but clear:

He didn’t need to say anything.

He just needed to be there.

That realization stayed with her long after the lecture began.

CHAPTER 8.9.3 — The Guy Who Tried to Walk Me Home

I didn't think it was a big deal.

That's the truth.

We were packing up after class, chairs scraping softly against the floor, everyone tired and eager to leave. I was stuffing my notebook into my bag when one of my classmates — friendly, familiar, harmless — stopped beside me.

“You shouldn't walk alone,” he said casually. “I can walk you to the bus stop.”

I blinked, surprised more than anything.

Oh. That's nice, I thought. But unnecessary.

“Oh, it's okay—” I started to say.

I didn't even finish the sentence.

Someone stepped into my space.

Him.

He appeared so suddenly that I actually startled — like a shadow materializing beside me. I hadn't heard his footsteps. I hadn't sensed him coming closer. One moment, he wasn't there... and the next, he was standing at my side, calm and solid.

“I’m going the same way,” he said evenly.

He didn’t look at the other boy.

“She won’t be alone.”

The words landed heavier than they should have.

I turned to look at him, surprised — not just by what he said, but by how natural it sounded. Not defensive. Not aggressive. Just... decided.

The classmate hesitated, awkwardness spreading across his face.

“Oh,” he said. “Okay then.”

He gave me a quick smile — polite, confused — and stepped back. As he walked away, I noticed something strange.

He didn’t.

Not immediately.

He stood there, gaze steady, following the boy’s retreating figure until he disappeared down the hallway. His posture was relaxed, but there was something unmistakably watchful in the way he held himself.

He’s making sure he actually leaves, I realized.

The thought sent a strange warmth through my chest.

When he finally turned back to me, I crossed my arms, trying to hide my reaction.

“Did you just scare him off?” I asked.

He shook his head calmly. “No.”

I tilted my head. “A little bit?”

“No,” he repeated, still calm, still composed.

I raised an eyebrow, unconvinced.

He avoided my eyes.

And that’s when my heart started doing something reckless.

He never avoided eye contact unless something mattered.

“Aura,” he said quietly.

The way he said my name made me straighten without meaning to.

“I don’t want anyone walking you but me.”

The words fell into the space between us and stayed there.

The moment they left his mouth, I saw it — the instant regret, the tightening of his jaw, the way his shoulders stiffened slightly like he was bracing for impact.

He hadn’t planned to say that.

He hadn’t measured it.

It was just... truth slipping out.

Oh.

My chest softened immediately.

I didn't feel offended.

I didn't feel controlled.

I felt... chosen.

I looked at him, really looked at him — the careful way he stood, the way his hands were loose at his sides like he was trying not to reach for me, the way his eyes flickered with uncertainty now that the words were out.

He's scared, I realized.

Not of me — but of what he just admitted.

"You don't get to decide that," I said gently.

He nodded. "I know."

"But," I continued, my voice softer now, "you didn't say it like an order."

He finally looked at me.

"I just..." He hesitated. "I worry."

That was all.

Not I'm jealous.

Not I don't like other guys around you.

Just I worry.

And something inside me melted completely.

We started walking together toward the exit. Side by side. Not touching, but close enough that I felt his presence like a quiet anchor.

When did this happen? I wondered.

When did I start feeling safest when he was near?

When did his worry start feeling comforting instead of suffocating?

As we stepped outside, the air cooler now, I realized something that made my steps slow slightly.

He didn't interrupt because he wanted to control me.

He stepped in because the idea of me walking alone bothered him.

Because somewhere along the way, he had decided — quietly, seriously — that my safety mattered to him.

A lot.

And that thought... scared me a little.

Not because it was unwanted.

But because it meant what I felt was no longer one-sided confusion.

It meant something was growing between us — something protective, something steady, something I wasn't sure how to name yet.

But I knew this much:

When he said, “She won't be alone,”
he wasn't just talking to that boy.

He was promising something.

And a part of me — a soft, honest part — wanted to let him keep that promise.

CHAPTER 8.9.4 — The Rumor

The rumor didn't reach me first.

It reached him.

He was walking across campus when someone said it casually, almost carelessly, like it didn't matter at all.

“Hey, did you hear? A guy from another department likes Aura.”

He stopped mid-step.

Not slowly.

Not thoughtfully.

His body reacted before his mind could catch up.

For a brief moment, the world seemed to tilt — like the ground beneath him had shifted just enough to make him lose balance. The sounds around him faded into something distant and dull. Laughter passed nearby. Footsteps echoed. None of it reached him properly.

A guy from another department.

The words repeated in his head, sharp and unwanted.

It wasn't anger that hit him.

It wasn't rage.

It was something quieter and deeper — a sudden, heavy pressure in his chest, like taking a breath that didn't fully go in. Something between fear and loss, settling painfully under his ribs.

He forced himself to keep walking.

But the rest of the day felt wrong.

I didn't know any of this when I saw him later that afternoon.

I was sitting outside near the building, iced tea sweating against my palm, pretending to enjoy the warmth while my mind wandered through unfinished thoughts. I didn't notice him approach until he was already there.

He sat down beside me.

Closer than usual.

Not touching — but close enough that I felt the heat of his arm through the thin space between us.

That's new, I thought.

I glanced at him, expecting his usual calm expression. Instead, he looked... tight. Not upset. Not cold. Just wound a little too carefully, like something inside him was being held back.

"Aura," he said softly.

The way he said my name made me straighten without meaning to.

"Do you... like someone?"

The question startled me so much I almost laughed — not because it was funny, but because it came out of nowhere.

“What?” I asked, blinking. “No. Why?”

He didn’t answer right away.

I watched his shoulders relax slightly, the tension easing like air slowly leaving a held breath.

“Good,” he said quietly.

The word landed heavier than it should have.

I stared at him.

Good?

“That...” I hesitated, studying his face, “that makes you happy?”

He nodded once.

“More than I should admit.”

Something in my chest skipped — then thudded hard.

I didn’t know what I had expected him to say, but it wasn’t that. There was no joking in his voice. No attempt to soften it. Just honesty, laid bare without protection.

I felt suddenly very still.

He cares, a voice inside me whispered.

Not casually. Not lightly.

I searched his face for signs of embarrassment, for him to pull back or laugh it off.

He didn't.

Instead, his gaze stayed on the ground between us, steady but exposed — like he had stepped too far forward and couldn't step back now.

"You heard something," I said slowly.

He nodded. "A rumor."

My fingers tightened slightly around the cup.

"A rumor about me?"

"Yes."

"And you believed it?" I asked, not accusing — just trying to understand.

"I didn't want to," he said. "But I couldn't stop thinking about it."

I swallowed.

This isn't small anymore, I realized. This isn't quiet comfort.

This was jealousy — not hidden, not disguised — standing openly between us.

And it scared me.

Not because it was ugly.

But because it was honest.

I had always thought jealousy would look loud or possessive. Raised voices. Arguments. Demands.

This wasn't that.

This was someone sitting beside me, heart clearly involved, risking vulnerability without asking for anything in return.

I turned my body slightly toward him.

"I don't like anyone," I said again, more firmly this time. "If I did, I'd tell you."

The words surprised me as much as they surprised him.

Why would I say that?

Since when do I owe anyone clarity like this?

But the truth was already there, shaping my choices before I fully understood them.

He finally looked at me then.

And something in his eyes — relief, warmth, restrained longing — made my chest ache.

"I'm glad," he said softly.

The silence that followed wasn't awkward.

It was heavy.

Full.

He's not hiding it anymore, I thought.

And neither am I.

I looked away first, suddenly too aware of how close we were, of how different the air felt now.

His jealousy was no longer something subtle I could ignore.

It was visible.

And more than that —

It meant something.

Something real.

Something that was no longer just hovering between us, unnamed and safe.

Something that, very soon, one of us would have to speak aloud.

HIS POV — The Rumor That Terrified Him

It was said casually.

Too casually.

Like it meant nothing.

“Hey, did you hear? Some guy from the business department likes Aura.”

He didn't respond.

Not because he didn't hear — but because everything inside him stopped moving. For a second, his body forgot what it was doing. One foot remained half-raised, frozen mid-step. The noise

around him blurred into something distant and meaningless. Voices passed. Laughter echoed. None of it reached him properly.

A guy from the business department.

The words replayed in his mind, sharp and intrusive.

What?

Who?

Since when?

His chest tightened, suddenly too small for his lungs.

Does she like him too?

Is he taller than me?

More confident?

Does he make her laugh the way I can't?

Does he say things I never dare to?

The questions came too fast, piling on top of each other before he could stop them.

He hated this feeling.

Hated how quickly his thoughts turned cruel — not toward her, but toward himself. He had always believed jealousy would feel loud, aggressive, ugly.

This wasn't that.

This was quiet panic.

This was fear.

His hands trembled slightly, and he shoved them into his pockets before anyone could notice. He forced himself to keep walking, but his legs felt weak, untrustworthy.

By the time he reached the bench near the building, he couldn't pretend anymore.

He sat down.

The moment he did, the ache in his chest sharpened — not pain exactly, but pressure. Like something important was slipping away and he didn't know how to stop it.

I don't get jealous, he told himself.

I don't compete.

But the truth pressed closer now.

He cared.

Too much.

The idea of someone else seeing her every day — someone new, someone confident enough to like her openly — made his stomach twist.

What if she chooses him?

The thought terrified him.

Not because he believed she owed him anything.

Not because he thought he had a claim on her.

But because he already knew what it felt like to be near her.

The calm.

The warmth.

The safety.

And the idea of losing that — of never being the one she leaned toward — felt unbearable.

He didn't want to ask her.

Asking meant risking the truth.

And the truth, whatever it was, could break something he wasn't ready to lose.

But he couldn't stay silent either.

The not knowing was worse.

When he found her later that afternoon, she was sitting outside with her iced tea, sunlight catching on the condensation of the cup. She looked peaceful — unaware, unburdened.

Seeing her like that almost made him turn away.

She looks fine, he thought.

Happy. Why would I bring this to her?

But the questions burned too deeply.

He sat beside her.

Closer than usual.

Not touching — but close enough that he could feel the warmth of her arm. He didn't look at her right away. He focused on the space in front of them, grounding himself.

Aura, he reminded himself. Just ask. Don't make it dramatic.

"Aura," he said softly.

She turned to him.

"Do you... like someone?"

The words came out steadier than he felt.

Inside, he braced.

He prepared himself for the worst — for hesitation, for confusion, for a gentle smile that would tell him everything he didn't want to hear.

Please, a quiet voice whispered inside him.

Please don't say yes.

When she said, "No," something incredible happened.

His body gave up the fight.

His shoulders dropped.

His chest loosened.

The pressure behind his eyes eased.

It felt like breathing after being underwater for too long.

For the first time in hours, his thoughts slowed.

No.

The word echoed softly inside him, not loud enough to celebrate, but deep enough to steady him.

He didn't smile.

He didn't laugh.

He didn't let the relief show.

But inside, something fragile unclenched.

Thank you, he whispered silently.

Thank you for not liking someone else.

When he said "Good," he surprised himself with how honest it sounded.

When she asked if it made him happy, he didn't lie.

"More than I should admit."

That was the truth.

And the truth scared him.

Because now he couldn't pretend anymore.

This wasn't just care.

This wasn't just concern.

This was attachment.

When he looked at her, really looked at her, he saw how easily he could lose her — not because she would hurt him, but because life simply moved forward whether he was brave enough or not.

He had always believed love should be steady, safe, planned.

But with her, it felt like standing at the edge of something deep — beautiful and terrifying at the same time.

He didn't say anything else.

He didn't need to.

Because now he knew:

The rumor hadn't just scared him.

It had revealed something he could no longer deny.

He wanted to be the one she chose.

And the thought — quiet, dangerous, hopeful — stayed with him long after they parted.

CHAPTER 8.9.5 — The Uneasy Feeling She Tried to Ignore

Aura didn't know when the feeling started.

It wasn't sudden.

It didn't announce itself.

It slipped in quietly, like a change in weather she didn't notice until the air felt heavier.

For days now, something had been different.

She caught herself watching him more than usual — not obviously, not deliberately — just small glances that lingered longer than they should have. The way he walked. The way he listened. The way his attention always seemed half-anchored to where she was, even when he pretended to focus on something else.

Why am I doing this? she asked herself.

She had never been the type to monitor anyone's presence. She believed in freedom, movement, distance. Attachment had always felt like something she could outgrow if she wasn't careful.

And yet...

When she didn't see him one afternoon where she expected to, a strange disappointment settled in her chest.

Not sharp.

Just... dull.

She shook it off. He's busy, she told herself. So am I.

But the excuse didn't fully work.

From a distance, he noticed her too.

She was quieter than usual. Less expressive. Her laughter didn't come as easily, and when it did, it faded quickly — like she didn't trust it to stay.

He didn't ask right away.

He never rushed things.

But the change didn't escape him.

Why does his attention matter so much to me now? Aura wondered later that night, sitting on her bed with her knees pulled close. Since when do I notice who he talks to... or how long he's gone?

The thought made her uncomfortable.

She didn't want to be this person — the one who cared silently, who measured feelings instead of expressing them openly. She liked being honest, straightforward.

But this wasn't something she knew how to say.

Because saying it would make it real.

The next day, she saw him across campus, talking with a few classmates. Nothing unusual. Nothing suspicious. Still, her steps slowed slightly.

Relax, she told herself. You're imagining things.

But her eyes followed him anyway.

When he laughed — quietly, briefly — something pinched in her chest.

That sound isn't just for me, she realized.

And the thought startled her.

She turned away quickly, annoyed at herself.

He doesn't belong to me, she reminded herself.

I don't get to feel this way.

But feelings didn't listen to rules.

Later, when they crossed paths near the library, he smiled at her the same way he always did — gentle, familiar.

"Hey," he said.

"Hey," she replied.

Normal.

Too normal.

And yet, the space between them felt different — charged with things neither of them had named yet.

She wanted to ask him something. She didn't know what.

Do you notice me the way I notice you?

Would it bother you if someone else stood here instead?

She said nothing.

That afternoon, as she walked through the corridor, she saw something that made her pause.

A girl from another class was approaching him.

Not confidently.

Not boldly.

Shyly.

Aura didn't stop walking — not fully — but her pace slowed just enough for her to notice details she hadn't intended to notice.

The girl held something in her hands. A snack. Wrapped carefully, like it mattered.

Aura's stomach tightened.

Why does that matter? she thought sharply. It's just a snack.

But her eyes betrayed her.

She saw the girl smile.

Saw her tuck her hair behind her ear.

Saw the hesitation before she stepped closer.

And suddenly, Aura understood.

Oh.

The realization settled uncomfortably.

Someone else liked him.

The thought twisted inside her chest, sharp and unfamiliar.

She looked away before the scene could burn itself deeper into her memory.

Don't be ridiculous, she told herself. You don't even know what he feels.

But her heart didn't listen.

It beat faster. Harder. Uneven.

And somewhere inside her, a truth she had been avoiding rose quietly to the surface.

This is jealousy.

Not loud.

Not dramatic.

Just real.

She walked on, pretending nothing had happened — unaware that this moment was only the beginning, that very soon, the feeling she tried to bury would demand to be seen.

CHAPTER 8.9.6 — The Girl Who Liked Him

Aura didn't mean to notice.

She was walking across campus, mind half-busy with unfinished thoughts, when something made her slow without realizing why. A small instinct — the kind that tugged at her chest before logic caught up.

That's when she saw him.

He was standing near the vending machines, backpack slung loosely over one shoulder, posture relaxed in that familiar way she had grown used to. For a brief second, relief warmed her chest.

There he is.

And then someone stepped into his space.

A girl.

Not someone Aura knew well — from another class, maybe another department. She moved hesitantly, holding a small snack in both hands like it was fragile, like it mattered.

Aura stopped walking.

She told herself she was just curious. That it was nothing. That she would look for one second and then move on.

But one second became many.

She saw how the girl smiled — shy, hopeful, careful.

Saw how she tucked her hair behind her ear before speaking.
Saw how she stepped just a little closer than necessary.

Aura's fingers tightened around her bag strap.

Why am I watching this? she thought sharply. It's not my business.

But her eyes refused to look away.

The girl said something Aura couldn't hear. She lifted the snack slightly, offering it with both hands. Aura watched his reaction closely — closer than she ever meant to.

He looked surprised.

Not pleased.

Not uncomfortable.

Just... caught off guard.

The girl laughed softly, then reached out — her fingers brushing lightly against his arm, tentative and hopeful.

Something twisted sharply inside Aura's chest.

Stop, she told herself. Don't do this.

But the feeling didn't stop.

It tightened.

It burned.

It hurt in a quiet way she wasn't prepared for.

Aura turned away abruptly, heart pounding, the image lingering behind her eyes like something she couldn't erase.

Why does this feel wrong?

Why does it feel like something is being taken from me?

She walked faster, annoyed at herself, annoyed at the tightness in her throat.

He doesn't belong to you, she reminded herself.

You don't get to feel this.

But feelings didn't listen.

They bloomed anyway — messy, unwanted, painfully honest.

Later that day, he noticed.

He always did.

Aura sat beside him during their break, iced tea untouched in her hand. She stared at nothing, her usual energy dimmed, her responses shorter.

“Are you okay?” he asked gently.

She didn't look at him. “Fine.”

The word came out too fast. Too sharp.

He frowned slightly, studying her face — the tight jaw, the way her eyes avoided his.

“You’re annoyed,” he said quietly.

“I said I’m fine.”

Silence stretched between them.

Not uncomfortable — just heavy.

Aura hated how exposed she felt. Hated that he could read her so easily. Hated that a moment she hadn’t even been part of had shaken her this much.

Say something, she told herself. Or don’t. Just stop feeling this.

But before she could decide, he spoke again.

His voice was softer now.

“Aura... she’s just a classmate.”

She froze.

“I didn’t accept anything,” he continued. “I don’t want anything from her.”

Aura’s breath softened before she could stop it.

The tension in her chest loosened slightly, like a hand slowly unclenching.

He noticed, she realized.

He saw me see it.

She turned to him then, eyes searching his face.

“Then what do you want?” she whispered.

The question surprised them both.

It wasn’t challenging.

It wasn’t playful.

It was honest.

He didn’t answer right away.

Instead, he looked at her — really looked — like he was weighing something fragile, something that could break if handled wrong.

The world around them faded.

“You,” he said quietly.

The word landed directly in her chest.

“But I don’t know if I’m allowed to say that yet.”

Aura felt heat rush to her face.

Her cheeks burned.

Her heart stumbled.

Allowed?

By who? By me? By himself?

She didn't know what to say. She didn't trust her voice.

She looked away first, overwhelmed by how close everything suddenly felt.

Jealousy had been there — sharp, uncomfortable, undeniable.

But now it had changed.

It wasn't pushing them apart.

It was pulling them closer.

Aura swallowed, her fingers tightening around her cup.

So this is it, she thought. This is what it feels like when feelings stop being safe.

She didn't say anything else.

Neither did he.

But the space between them felt different now — thinner, warmer, charged with words that had almost been spoken and truths that could no longer be hidden.

Jealousy had shown itself.

On both sides.

And instead of tearing them apart, it had done something far more dangerous.

It had brought them closer to the edge of honesty.

HIS POV — The Girl Who Liked Him (But He Only Looked at Aura)

He noticed her before she spoke.

Not because she was loud or confident, but because she moved carefully — the way people do when they are nervous. She approached him with small steps, holding something in both hands like it was important, like it carried meaning.

A snack, he realized.

Before she even opened her mouth, he knew.

He had seen this before. Not often, but enough to recognize it — the hesitation, the polite smile, the way she stopped just a little too close.

She likes me.

The thought didn't flatter him.

It made him uncomfortable.

She said his name softly. Offered the snack with a shy laugh. He nodded, surprised but polite, because that was who he was. He didn't want to embarrass her. He didn't want to be cruel without reason.

So he accepted it.

“Thank you,” he said.

But his body felt wrong the moment he did.

This wasn't what he wanted.

When her fingers brushed his arm lightly — just a brief, hopeful touch — his muscles stiffened instinctively.

No.

The word rang clearly in his head.

I don't want this.

I don't want her.

The realization came without hesitation, without confusion.

I only want—

His thoughts stopped.

Because his eyes had already moved.

Across the open space of campus, he saw Aura.

She had slowed. Not completely stopped — just enough. Her posture was still, but her face wasn't. He caught the exact moment her expression shifted.

The hurt.

It wasn't dramatic. It wasn't obvious. But he knew her too well now not to see it — the way her lips pressed together, the way her gaze turned away too quickly, like she didn't want him to notice.

Something inside his chest cracked open.

No. No, no.

He wanted to call out to her. Wanted to explain. Wanted to tell her she had it wrong — that nothing about this mattered, that the snack meant nothing, that the girl meant nothing.

When Aura turned and walked away, his instinct screamed at him to follow.

Run after her.

Stop her.

Fix this.

But he didn't.

He stayed where he was, jaw tight, fingers curling slowly around the wrapper in his hand like it was something he wished he could disappear.

I hate this, he thought. I hate that she saw it.

The girl said something else — maybe asking a question, maybe making another joke — but he barely heard it. His attention was gone. Entirely.

When the girl finally left, relief washed over him — but it was too late.

The damage was already done.

Later that day, when he found Aura again, the change was immediate.

She was quieter.

Too controlled.

Her usual warmth was there, but muted — like she was holding something back. She answered him, but quickly. Looked away too often. Kept her distance without saying why.

She's upset, he realized.

No... she's jealous.

The thought hit him so hard he almost stopped walking.

Aura is jealous?

Of me?

His heart beat faster, a mix of disbelief and something dangerously close to hope.

Does that mean...?

He didn't let the thought finish.

Instead, he sat beside her and asked gently, "Are you okay?"

"Fine," she said too fast.

He studied her face carefully. He always did. He had learned her expressions the way one learns a language — slowly, patiently, until the smallest changes spoke loudly.

"You're annoyed," he said quietly.

"I said I'm fine."

The words were sharp, but not cruel.

She's hurt, he realized. And it's my fault.

Silence stretched between them, thick and fragile. He didn't want to push. Didn't want to scare her. But this wasn't something he could leave unspoken.

"Aura," he said gently.

She didn't look at him.

"She's just a classmate," he continued. "I didn't accept anything because I wanted it. I don't want anything from her."

He watched closely as her shoulders relaxed — just slightly. The tension in her posture eased in a way that told him everything.

She cares.

The relief that followed was dangerous.

Then she whispered, barely audible, "Then what do you want?"

The question froze him.

Not because he didn't know the answer.

But because saying it would change everything.

He turned to her fully then. Looked straight into her eyes — the same eyes he had been quietly choosing for weeks now, without ever admitting it to himself.

“You,” he said.

The word felt steady. Certain.

“And for the first time, I didn’t regret it.”

Her cheeks flushed, heat rising quickly, and his heart clenched at the sight — not with fear, but with something tender and fierce.

He had always believed honesty should be careful.

But in that moment, he understood something new.

Some truths are too important to keep quiet.

And even if he didn’t know what came next — even if everything became complicated from here — he knew one thing with absolute clarity:

He didn’t want anyone else.

He had never wanted anyone else.

And for the first time, he let himself hope that maybe... just maybe...

She wanted him too.

CHAPTER 8.9.7 — The Day He Finally Got Scared of Losing You

It started as nothing.

Just a thought spoken out loud, casual and unguarded, the way Aura always talked about new ideas when they crossed her mind.

“I’m thinking about joining a club,” she said, absently stirring her drink.

He looked up from his notebook, surprised but calm. Aura was always curious, always reaching for something new. It was one of the things he admired about her — the way she moved forward without fear.

“Oh?” he said lightly. “Which one?”

She shrugged. “I haven’t decided yet. Maybe the debate club. Or the volunteer group.”

He nodded, pretending the thought didn’t bother him.

Of course she wants more, he thought. She always does.

“Who’s in that club?” he asked, keeping his tone neutral, careful not to sound like he was digging for something.

Aura named a few people. Familiar names. Classmates. Nothing unusual.

Then she said one more.

A boy.

Not just any boy — someone he recognized immediately. Someone loud. Confident. Someone who laughed easily and took up space without asking permission.

His heart sank.

He didn't react right away. He didn't interrupt. He didn't show it. But something inside him dropped, heavy and sudden, like missing a step you didn't know was there.

"Oh," he said quietly.

Aura didn't notice at first. She kept talking, explaining why the club sounded interesting, how busy it would be, how much time it might take.

"You'll spend a lot of time there?" he asked.

The question came out softer than he intended.

She nodded. "Yeah, I guess."

He looked down at his hands.

So she'll be there, he thought. With him.

"You'll be..." He hesitated, then finished the thought anyway. "Around him a lot."

Aura stopped talking.

She looked at him properly then.

Something in his voice had changed — not sharp, not accusing — just... uncertain. Exposed.

Oh, she realized.

That's what this is.

She studied his face — the way his jaw tightened slightly, the way his eyes refused to meet hers, the way his shoulders held tension like he was bracing himself.

He's not jealous, she thought.

He's scared.

“Are you scared?” she asked softly.

He didn't answer.

He didn't shake his head.

He didn't deny it.

He just stayed silent.

And the silence said everything.

Aura felt her chest tighten.

So this is what he's afraid of, she thought. Not losing control. Not competition.

Losing me.

She reached out without thinking, her fingers brushing gently against his arm. The contact was light, careful — but grounding.

“I’m not going anywhere,” she whispered.

The words surprised her with how true they felt.

He froze at her touch, then slowly looked up.

His eyes were soft now — not guarded, not analytical — just open. Honest. Vulnerable in a way she had never seen before.

“Promise?” he asked quietly.

The single word carried more weight than any long speech.

Promise you won’t drift away.

Promise you won’t choose someone else.

Promise I won’t wake up one day and realize I waited too long.

Aura didn’t hesitate.

“Promise.”

She meant it.

She saw the way his breath eased, the way his shoulders relaxed, the way something tight inside him finally loosened.

For the first time, he let himself believe her.

And Aura realized something important in that moment.

This wasn’t about clubs.

This wasn't about another boy.

This was about fear — the kind that only appears when you care deeply enough to lose something.

She squeezed his arm gently before pulling her hand back.

I never thought I'd be someone's fear, she thought.

Or someone's safe place.

But here she was.

And here he was — no longer hiding how much she mattered.

They sat in silence after that, not awkward, not heavy — just quiet in a way that felt earned.

The world moved around them, unaware that something fragile had just been spoken aloud and protected.

And for the first time, neither of them pretended this was just friendship anymore.

CHAPTER 8.9.8 — When Distance Was No Longer Possible

It happened in small steps.

So small that Aura almost didn't notice at first.

She was standing near the campus café, waiting for a friend, scrolling through her phone when she heard a familiar voice again.

"Hey," the guy said, smiling too easily. "Coffee this time? Just a quick one."

Aura looked up and felt the familiar discomfort settle in her chest.

She had already said no.

Three times.

Politely. Calmly. Clearly.

"I really can't," she said again, keeping her tone gentle. "I'm not interested."

He laughed awkwardly, like he didn't quite believe her. Like persistence might still change something.

"Well, maybe another—"

Before Aura could finish her sentence, a presence appeared behind her.

Close.

Solid.

Him.

He didn't rush in.

He didn't raise his voice.

He simply stepped into the space behind her like he belonged there.

"She said she's not interested," he said quietly.

Aura felt it instantly — the shift in the air.

The guy turned, surprised. "Dude, I'm just asking—"

"Don't ask again."

His voice was calm. Soft, even.

But there was no space for negotiation in it.

The kind of finality that didn't need volume to be heard.

The guy hesitated, frowned, then shrugged uncomfortably. "Alright. Chill."

He backed away and left without another word.

Aura stood frozen for a moment.

Her heart was racing — not from fear, but from something else entirely.

She turned to him, stunned.

“You didn’t have to—”

“Yes, I did.”

The certainty in his voice stopped her.

“Why?” she asked, softer now.

He looked at her then — really looked — and for once, he didn’t hide behind restraint or careful silence.

“Because it bothers me,” he said quietly, “when someone else tries to take you from me.”

Aura’s breath hitched.

Take me?

From where? From who?

From him.

The truth settled heavy and undeniable between them.

His jealousy was no longer something subtle she could pretend not to see. It wasn’t quiet anymore. It wasn’t hidden behind concern or politeness.

It was real.

And it scared her — not because it felt wrong, but because it felt honest.

She didn't answer right away.

She didn't know how.

Because some part of her had been waiting to hear those words, even if she hadn't admitted it yet.

After that, everything changed.

Not all at once.

But enough to be felt.

When they walked together later that evening, he didn't keep his usual careful distance. He walked closer — close enough that their arms brushed with every few steps.

Aura noticed immediately.

Is this on purpose? she wondered.

Their steps matched without effort. Slower. Aligned. Like their bodies had quietly agreed on the same rhythm.

She felt more aware of him than ever — of the warmth beside her, of the way his presence no longer hovered but stayed.

At one point, she stumbled slightly on uneven pavement.

Before she could even react, his hand was there.

Fingers wrapping gently but firmly around her wrist.

“You okay?” he whispered.

His voice was low, full of worry — instinctive, unfiltered.

Aura nodded, cheeks warm. “Yeah.”

He didn’t let go right away.

Not until she was fully steady.

Not until he was sure.

And even then... his eyes lingered on her hand, still wrapped loosely in his grip, as if he were silently asking himself a question he wasn’t brave enough to ask out loud.

Am I allowed to hold her?

Aura felt it.

The hesitation.

The restraint.

The want.

Her heart beat faster.

She didn’t pull away immediately.

Neither did he.

When their hands finally separated, the absence felt louder than the touch itself.

They kept walking.

Closer than before.

And Aura realized something she couldn't unfeel anymore.

This wasn't just jealousy.

This was choosing.

Choosing to step closer instead of back.

Choosing honesty over safety.

Choosing each other — quietly, without a declaration, but unmistakably.

She glanced at him from the corner of her eye.

He was watching the path ahead, jaw set, expression calm — but his shoulder stayed just close enough to hers to say what he hadn't spoken yet.

He's not backing away anymore, she thought.

And neither was she.

CHAPTER 8.9.9 — The Day Care Became Something He Couldn't Hide

The rain came suddenly.

One moment the sky was only gray, heavy with promise. The next, water fell in thick sheets, drenching the campus paths and sending students running for cover. Aura had no umbrella — again — and by the time she reached the building entrance, her hair clung to her face and her clothes were soaked through.

She was breathless, half-laughing, half-annoyed, when she looked up.

And saw him.

Standing just under the edge of the roof.

Holding an umbrella.

Waiting.

For her.

Her heart skipped.

Of course he's here, she thought — not surprised at all, and yet stunned by how right it felt.

“You'll get sick,” he murmured immediately, stepping forward and lifting the umbrella over her head, shielding her as if the rain had been meant only for her.

Aura stared at him. “But you're getting wet.”

“I don’t care.”

The answer was instant. No hesitation. No calculation.

He pulled her a little closer under the umbrella, instinctive and careful at the same time. Their shoulders pressed together, warmth blooming between them despite the cold rain. Her hand brushed against his.

Thunder rumbled overhead.

Aura’s heart felt unsteady — not from the storm, but from the way he stood so close now, no longer pretending distance was enough.

“Aura...” he said quietly.

She looked up at him.

“I can’t stop worrying about you.”

The words were soft. Honest. Almost helpless.

Something inside her melted completely.

This isn’t just concern, she realized.

This is attachment.

She didn’t answer right away. She just stood there with him, rain falling around them, feeling protected in a way that reached deeper than shelter.

They walked together after that, slower than necessary, umbrella tilted to cover her more than him.

And Aura knew — without doubt — that this wasn't accidental anymore.

Later that week, the shift came again.

Aura was laughing with someone after class — nothing special, nothing flirtatious. Just friendliness. Conversation. Ease.

But when she turned toward him, she noticed it immediately.

He was quiet.

Not distant in anger.

Not cold.

Just... withdrawn.

Too careful.

Her steps slowed.

What happened now? she wondered.

They walked side by side in silence longer than usual. The quiet pressed in on her chest, uncomfortable in a way silence with him never had been before.

She stopped.

“Did I do something wrong?”

He looked surprised. “No.”

“Then why are you distant?”

He didn’t answer right away.

He looked down, jaw tightening slightly, like he was choosing his words from a place that felt dangerous.

“Because sometimes,” he said slowly, “I don’t know if I’m allowed to feel jealous.”

Aura’s breath caught.

“Or if I’m overreacting,” he continued. “Or if you’ll think I’m weird for caring this much.”

Her heart softened instantly.

Oh, she thought. You’re not pulling away. You’re scared.

She stepped closer.

“You’re not weird,” she whispered.

He looked up.

“And... you’re allowed to feel things.”

The words settled into him visibly. She watched relief cross his face — subtle but real — like something heavy had finally been set down.

He met her eyes fully now.

For the first time, his jealousy didn’t feel like something he was ashamed of.

It felt like proof.

Proof that he cared.

That he was invested.

That he was no longer pretending this was simple.

Aura smiled gently.

We're both scared, she realized.

But we're still here.

And that mattered more than anything else.

The rain had stopped by then. The air felt clean, calm, like the world had paused to give them space.

They didn't say anything else.

They didn't need to.

Because care had already crossed into something deeper — something neither of them could ignore anymore.

And from this point on, pretending was no longer an option.

CHAPTER 8.9.10 — The Words He Almost Said, and the Choice He Finally Made

They were sitting on the steps outside the building, sharing snacks they had bought without much thought. The afternoon was calm, the kind that made time feel slower than usual. Students passed occasionally, but not close enough to break the quiet bubble around them.

Aura laughed at something he said.

Not a polite laugh.

Not a small one.

A real laugh — light, warm, unguarded.

He stopped breathing for half a second.

He stared at her.

Openly this time.

Not careful.

Not hiding.

Her face was lit softly by the afternoon sun, eyes bright, shoulders relaxed. She looked happy. Comfortable. Like she belonged exactly where she was.

I can't do this anymore, he thought.

I can't keep pretending.

His heart pounded hard enough that he felt it in his throat. He leaned forward slightly, voice dropping without meaning to.

“Aura...” he whispered.

She tilted her head, still smiling. “You what?”

The question was gentle. Curious. Inviting.

His chest tightened.

“I...” His voice shook. He swallowed. “I really—”

Footsteps.

Too close.

Laughter. Voices. A group of students walking up the stairs behind them.

The moment shattered.

His body reacted before his mind could catch up. He shut down instantly, eyes dropping, shoulders pulling back like he had touched something dangerous.

“Never mind,” he said quickly.

Too quickly.

Aura’s smile faded just a little.

She didn’t press him.

Didn't ask again.

But she knew.

She heard it in the break of his voice.

In the way his hands clenched slightly.

In the silence that followed — heavy, unfinished.

He was about to say something, she realized.

Something important.

They sat there for a while longer, talking about smaller things, but the air between them had changed. Something had almost crossed the line.

And neither of them could forget it.

Later that day, they walked together across campus.

Aura walked a few steps ahead of him, sunlight catching in her hair. She turned around suddenly and smiled at him.

Not a small smile.

Not a careful one.

A full, bright, beautiful smile.

And something inside him broke.

Not loudly.

Not violently.

Just... completely.

I can't keep this inside anymore.

The thought came clear and undeniable.

If I don't tell her now... I'll regret it forever.

He stopped walking.

"Aura," he called out.

She turned. "Yes?"

His heart hammered painfully. His hands felt cold. His voice trembled despite his effort to keep it steady.

"Can you... meet me tomorrow?"

Her brow furrowed slightly. "Tomorrow?"

"At the garden behind the school," he added quickly. "After classes."

She blinked, surprised. "Sure. Why?"

He looked at her for a long second.

He wanted to tell her everything right then. Wanted to say the words that had been pressing against his chest for weeks now. Wanted to be honest without interruption.

But he wasn't ready yet.

Not here.

Not like this.

“I need to tell you something important,” he said quietly.

Aura’s heart raced.

She nodded slowly. “Okay.”

As she turned and walked away again, the world felt different — sharper, louder, more fragile.

He stood there for a moment after she left, staring at the path ahead.

Tomorrow, he thought.

Tomorrow I won’t stop myself.

Because some feelings don’t fade when ignored.

They grow heavier.

And tomorrow, in the quiet garden behind the school, he would finally let the truth breathe.

☾ SPECIAL CHAPTER — The Almost Ending

Before the Beginning

It began with something small.

So small that neither of them understood, in that moment, how powerful it would become.

A glance.

A pause.

A misunderstanding born from silence.

And silence, when feelings are fragile, can be louder than any argument.

☾ 1. The Moment Everything Shifted

Aura was walking toward the cafeteria when she saw him.

He was standing near one of the tables by the windows, body relaxed, backpack resting against his leg. At first, relief bloomed in her chest.

There you are.

Then she saw her.

A girl.

Not the one from before.

Someone new.

She had long hair that fell softly over her shoulders, a gentle smile, a quiet confidence that made Aura slow without realizing it. The girl leaned in slightly as she spoke, voice low, familiar—as if this wasn't their first conversation.

Aura's steps faltered.

Why does she look so comfortable with him?

He looked... easy. Calm. The way he usually was with Aura.

Too easy.

Her stomach tightened.

They look close.

She told herself to keep walking. To turn away. To pretend she hadn't seen anything. But her body refused to move, as if her feet had forgotten how.

Then she saw it.

The girl handed him a small bag.

He took it.

He smiled.

He said thank you.

That was all.

But it felt like too much.

Aura turned away immediately—heart pounding, chest tight, breath shallow.

Not fast enough.

Because at that exact moment, he looked up.

And he saw her walking away.

Fast.

Stiff.

Gone.

His eyes widened.

Something deep in his chest twisted sharply, sudden and alarming, like losing balance without warning.

Why does that feel like loss?

© 2. HIS POV — Confusion That Turns Into Fear

When he saw Aura walk away like that—

Quick steps.

Rigid shoulders.

Her head lowered like she didn't want to be seen—

His entire body went cold.

Did she see?

Did she misunderstand?

Did she think that girl means something to me?

The bag in his hand suddenly felt heavy.

He didn't even like the girl.

He had been polite. That was all. He had always been polite—it was easier than hurting someone's feelings. But Aura turning away like that felt like something vital had been pulled out of him.

She thinks I chose someone else.

The realization hit him like a blow.

He wanted to follow her.

Wanted to explain.

Wanted to tell her that the girl meant nothing.

That he only wanted—

But his feet wouldn't move.

Fear wrapped around him like chains.

What if she doesn't care?

What if I imagined everything between us?

What if she's already decided I don't matter?

He stayed where he was.

And hated himself for it.

He hated the bag.

Hated the timing.

Hated how much Aura mattered to him.

And most of all, he hated how easily she could hurt him—
without even knowing she was doing it.

© 3. Aura Tries to Pretend She's Fine

Aura spent the rest of the day pretending.

Pretending she didn't care.

Pretending her chest didn't ache.

Pretending her thoughts weren't replaying the scene again and again.

She wasn't angry.

She was scared.

Maybe he doesn't like me.

Maybe he likes her.

Maybe I imagined everything.

She told herself she was being dramatic. Told herself she had no right to feel this way. They weren't together. He wasn't hers.

But her heart didn't understand logic.

Her heart only understood pain.

She avoided him.

In class, she stared at her notebook.

During breaks, she walked the long way around.

When she felt his presence nearby, she left—quickly.

Every time, it hurt.

But she couldn't stop.

Because if he likes someone else...

I need to distance myself.

© 4. HIS POV — Watching Her Avoid Him

She avoided him.

Completely.

He felt it everywhere.

The hallway she no longer walked down.

The way she pulled out her phone the moment she saw him.

The way her eyes slid past him like he wasn't there.

Each moment cut deeper.

What did I do?

Did I hurt her?

Does she hate me now?

He replayed the moment over and over.

Her face when she saw him.

The way she turned away.

The silence that followed.

That afternoon, he gathered the courage to approach her in the library.

When he walked toward her table, she packed her things abruptly and stood.

“I—I have class.”

“Aura,” he called out.

She froze.

Just for a second.

Then she walked away again.

And this time—

It broke him.

© 5. The Breaking Point

That evening, Aura went to the courtyard.

She sat alone beneath the dimming sky, hugging her knees, trying not to cry. The air was cool, quiet, forgiving.

She wasn't angry at him.

She was angry at herself.

Why am I like this?

Why am I jealous?

Why do I care so much?

She had no right.

They weren't together.

He hadn't promised her anything.

But her heart didn't listen.

Her heart only hurt.

She whispered into the empty air, voice breaking:

“Why does it hurt so much...?”

She didn't know he was standing behind her.

Didn't know he had seen her shoulders shaking.

Didn't know he had heard her whisper.

© 6. HIS POV — The Moment He Couldn't Stay Silent

Seeing her like that shattered him.

The tears she tried to hide.

The way she curled into herself.

Something inside him cracked open.

He walked toward her slowly, fear and determination tangled together.

“Aura...”

She stiffened, wiping her eyes quickly.

“You shouldn’t be here,” she whispered.

He sat beside her anyway.

Not too close.

Not too far.

“I need to talk to you,” he said. “I think... you misunderstood something.”

She looked away.

“No, it’s fine. You don’t owe me anything.”

The softness in her voice hurt more than anger ever could.

“I don’t want you to think I like her,” he said quickly.

“You looked... comfortable,” she murmured.

“I wasn’t,” he whispered. “I was uncomfortable the whole time.”

She swallowed.

“She gave you something.”

“I didn’t want it. I only accepted it to not be rude.”

Her breath shook.

“I thought...”

“What?”

“I thought maybe you liked her.”

His heart stopped.

He stared at her—realizing, for the first time, that she had been afraid of losing him.

“Aura,” he said, voice trembling, “I don’t like her.”

She turned to him, eyes shining.

“Then who do you like?”

© 7. Aura’s Heart Finally Breaks Open

Aura pressed a hand to her chest.

“You... like me?”

He nodded.

“I’ve liked you for a long time. Since before the laptop. Since the corridor. Since every moment after.”

Tears spilled down her cheeks.

Not from sadness.

From relief.

“I thought I misunderstood everything,” she whispered.

“No,” he said softly. “You didn’t. You’re the only one I wait for. The only one I look for in crowds.”

Her breath caught.

“And the girl from today?”

“She’s nothing compared to you.”

© 8. The Almost-Confession

(The Moment Before Chapter 9)

The courtyard was quiet.

The wind moved gently.

He reached out, hesitated—

then touched her hand.

Aura didn't pull away.

"Aura... tomorrow... can you meet me in the garden?" he asked.

She nodded.

"Why?"

"Because I want to tell you everything."

She smiled through tears.

"I'll be there."

He stood, took a few steps—

then turned back.

"So please... don't avoid me anymore."

"I won't."

And as he walked away, heart racing, he knew—

Tomorrow...

he would confess for real.

🌙 SPECIAL CHAPTER — HIS POV: The Almost Ending Before the Beginning

I didn't know it would start like that.

I didn't know a moment so small could feel like the end of everything.

I was standing near the cafeteria, half-listening to someone talk, when it happened.

A girl approached me.

Not Aura.

Someone else.

She smiled politely, said my name like she had practiced it beforehand, and handed me a small bag. I already knew what it meant. I always knew. People don't approach you like that without hope in their eyes.

I didn't want it.

But I didn't want to hurt her either.

So I did what I always do — I accepted it politely, said thank you, kept my voice calm. I told myself it didn't matter. That it meant nothing.

And then I felt it.

That quiet shift in the air.

I looked up.

Aura.

She was walking away.

Fast. Too fast.

Her shoulders were stiff. Her head was lowered, like she didn't want me to see her face.

My heart stopped.

No—

No, no, no.

Did she see?

Did she misunderstand?

Does she think I chose someone else?

My chest tightened so suddenly it felt physical, like someone had struck me. I wanted to call her name. Wanted to drop everything and run after her.

But I didn't move.

Fear wrapped around me instantly.

What if she doesn't care?

What if I imagined everything between us?

What if she's walking away because she's already done?

The bag in my hand felt heavy. Wrong. Like proof of something I never wanted.

I hated it.

I hated that she saw me holding something from someone else.

I hated that I couldn't explain.

I hated that I didn't know how much she meant to me until I thought I'd lost her.

And I hated how easily she could break me without even knowing.

After that, she disappeared.

Not physically — she was still on campus — but from me.

Every hallway she avoided.

Every time she pretended not to see me.

Every time her eyes passed over me like I wasn't there.

It hurt more than I knew how to handle.

Did I do this?

Did I ruin everything by being polite to the wrong person at the wrong time?

I replayed the moment endlessly.

Her face.

Her retreat.

The silence she left behind.

I finally gathered the courage to approach her in the library.

The moment she saw me coming, she packed her things and stood up.

“I—I have class.”

“Aura,” I said.

She froze.

Just for a second.

Then she walked away again.

That second time hurt worse.

It felt final.

That evening, I found her in the courtyard.

She was sitting alone, hugging her knees, staring at the ground like she was holding herself together by force. I saw her shoulders shake slightly.

I heard her whisper.

“Why does it hurt so much...?”

Something inside me broke open.

I didn’t care about fear anymore.

I walked toward her slowly, heart pounding, hands shaking.

“Aura...”

She wiped her eyes quickly, like she didn’t want me to see.

“You shouldn’t be here,” she whispered.

I sat beside her anyway.

Not touching.

Not crowding.

Just close enough to be honest.

“I need to talk to you,” I said. “I think you misunderstood something.”

She looked away. “It’s fine. You don’t owe me anything.”

The way she said it — gentle, sad, resigned — hurt more than anger ever could.

“I don’t want you to think I like her,” I said quickly.

“You looked comfortable,” she murmured.

“I wasn’t,” I said. “I was uncomfortable the whole time.”

“She gave you something.”

“I didn’t want it. I only accepted it to be polite.”

Her breath shook.

“I thought maybe you liked her.”

My heart stopped.

She thought she was losing me.

The realization hit me so hard I had to steady myself.

“Aura,” I said, voice breaking, “I don’t like her.”

She finally looked at me.

“Then who do you like?”

I inhaled deeply.

My hands trembled.

My chest burned.

“You,” I whispered. “I only like you.”

Saying it felt terrifying.

And right.

She cried.

Not from sadness.

From relief.

And when she said she thought she had misunderstood everything, something inside me softened completely.

“No,” I told her. “You didn’t misunderstand. You’re the only one I wait for. The only one I look for in crowds.”

When she asked about the girl again, I shook my head immediately.

“She’s nothing compared to you.”

And I meant it.

The courtyard was quiet.

The wind moved gently.

I reached for her hand, hesitated — afraid she’d pull away — then touched it softly.

She stayed.

“Aura... tomorrow... can you meet me in the garden?” I asked.

She nodded.

“Why?”

“Because I want to tell you everything,” I said. “Not just pieces.”

She smiled through tears.

“I’ll be there.”

I stood up slowly, took a few steps away, then turned back.

“So please... don’t avoid me anymore.”

“I won’t,” she said.

As I walked away, my heart racing, one thought stayed with me:

I almost lost her.

And tomorrow —

I would finally make sure she knew

I wasn’t going anywhere.

CHAPTER 9 — The Confession in the Garden

The garden behind the university was always quiet near sunset.

It sat just far enough from the main buildings that most students never bothered to walk there unless they had a reason. Tall trees filtered the light into soft gold, leaves whispering gently whenever the wind passed through. The paths were narrow, uneven, and rarely crowded — a place that felt untouched by urgency.

Aura arrived slowly.

Her heart raced, though she wasn't entirely sure why. She told herself it was just curiosity, just nerves over an important conversation. But deep down, she knew it was more than that.

He wouldn't ask me to meet him here for nothing.

She spotted him near the center of the garden.

He stood with his hands in his pockets, shoulders slightly tense, staring down at the ground as if rehearsing something in his mind. He looked different here — softer somehow, stripped of the campus noise that usually surrounded them.

For a moment, she just watched him.

He looks nervous, she realized.

He's never nervous.

"You wanted to talk?" she asked softly.

He looked up.

Their eyes met, and for a brief second, his calm exterior cracked completely. What she saw beneath it made her chest tighten — nerves, vulnerability, and something dangerously close to longing.

He nodded.

“Yes.”

He inhaled deeply, then exhaled slowly, like he was bracing himself.

“I’ve been trying to find the right words,” he said at last. His voice was steady, but only barely.

“I’m not good at... feelings.”

Aura didn’t interrupt.

She stayed where she was, hands relaxed at her sides, giving him the space he clearly needed.

He swallowed.

“I like you,” he said quietly. “More than I should. More than I expected.”

Her heart thumped so loudly she was sure he could hear it.

“I’ve liked you since the day I helped you with your laptop,” he continued, voice shaking just slightly now. “And even before that... I noticed you. Not in a weird way. Just—”

He paused, searching for the right words.

“You stood out.”

Aura’s throat tightened.

She remembered that day clearly — the frustration, the small kindness, the way his presence had felt steady even then. She hadn't known it mattered to him too.

His voice softened.

"You're strong," he said. "Brave. You act like you don't need anyone, but... I can see when you're tired. When you're overwhelmed."

Her chest ached.

"I want to help," he went on. "I want to understand you. Not fix you — just... be there."

He hesitated, then took a small step closer.

"I know I'm quiet," he whispered. "And I know I'm not the type of guy girls usually want."

That sentence hit her harder than she expected.

Her eyes stung.

"But I want to get to know you properly," he finished. "Not as classmates. As something more."

Aura stepped closer too — close enough to hear his uneven breathing, close enough to feel the warmth he carried so naturally.

"You think you're not what girls want," she said softly.

He looked at her, uncertainty flickering across his face.

"But you're exactly what I want."

His eyes widened — just a fraction — shock, relief, and hope crashing together in silence.

“Then...” he whispered. “We can try?”

Aura nodded, a small smile breaking through the emotion in her chest.

“I want to try with you,” she said.

He let out a shaky breath, shoulders finally relaxing, like he’d been holding everything in for far too long.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

The garden seemed to breathe with them — leaves rustling softly, the last light of day wrapping around their figures like a promise. No one else was there to hear the confession, to witness the moment.

The garden held their secret.

The wind carried it gently.

Two hearts, finally meeting in the open.

Not rushed.

Not chaotic.

Just truth.

And for the first time, the slow-burn love they had been circling for so long finally caught its first flame.

Not loud.

Not overwhelming.

But steady — and real.